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SUMMIT CONCLUDES: INITIATIVES INCLUDE EARLY WARNING SYSTEM ON INFECTIOUS DISEASES, SUPPLY CHAIN FRAMEWORK

## Modi flags 'weaponisation' of tech; Xi announces open-source AI for BRICS



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses a session on the second day of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, Sunday. On the right are Chinese President Xi Jinping, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian; on the left are Russian President Vladimir Putin, Egypt's President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto and Kazakhstan President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev. MEA

### Global South should jointly advance better governance structure, says Putin

Shubhajit Roy & Divya A  
New Delhi, September 13

ON A day when Prime Minister Narendra Modi warned that "the weaponisation of technology and critical minerals" could hinder progress and underlined the need for "inclusivity", Chinese President Xi Jinping on Sunday announced that Beijing would lead the creation of an open-source AI ecosystem for BRICS member nations.

Modi's remarks are seen as an oblique reference to Beijing's control over the critical mineral supply chain and the US-China leverage battle over access to technology. He was speaking at the concluding session of the two-day BRICS Summit, with Xi, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, among other leaders, in attendance.

Xi, who spoke after Modi, made the announcement as part of a five-point initiative to boost cooperation in technology, manufacturing and trade, even as he called on the bloc to focus on building a large integrated market comprising emerging economies. This is seen as an effort to position Beijing as a central technology partner for BRICS amid its grow-

### Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



ing AI competition with the US.

In a statement, the Chinese Foreign Ministry said Xi called upon BRICS leaders to work towards writing a "new chapter of strength through unity for the Global South", and asserted that the logic that "might makes right" should have been discarded long ago.

Putin, in his address, urged the Global South countries to "jointly advance better (global) governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats."

Addressing the BRICS leaders' outreach summit, attended by the grouping's

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Russian President Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping depart from New Delhi, Sunday. MEA



### EXPRESS special

## What led to Iran-UAE consensus: Ceasefire window, 100-hour talks, back-and-forth at top level, nudge from China and Russia

The Indian Express pieces together how BRICS talks moved on the inside track



India's BRICS Sherpa Sudhakar Dalela, Sous Sherpa Shambhu Lingappa Hakki, Joint Secretaries Rajiv Bodwade and Dr Basir Ahmad, and Director Mini Devi Kumam worked closely with the teams of other BRICS member countries regularly

Shubhajit Roy  
New Delhi, September 13

A NARROW ceasefire window, talks at the highest level, a nudge from Beijing and Moscow, support from Egypt and Brazil, and nearly 100 hours of down-to-

the-wire negotiations by Indian diplomats — with experience ranging from Geneva and Washington to Beijing and the WTO — fell into place to produce the fraught consensus on the war in West Asia in the BRICS joint declaration Saturday.

Speaking to officials involved, *The Indian Express* has pieced together this journey, which began 17 days before the US and Israel attacked Iran and killed its Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei.

It was at the first BRICS

Sherpas meeting, held in New Delhi from February 9 to 11, that priorities under India's chairship were outlined. Once war broke out on February 28, the rulebook went for a toss.

At the second Sherpas' »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

### IRAN, GULF COUNCIL TO DISCUSS HORMUZ TODAY

## Agreed to put the past behind, look to future: Pezeshkian on Iran-UAE meet

Shubhajit Roy  
New Delhi, September 13

A DAY after meeting Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khalid bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit here, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on Sunday said they had "agreed to put the past behind... and look to the future".

This is a rare moment from Delhi, where Iranian and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) leaders met for the first time since the West Asia war began. Following hectic negotiations,



Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian departs from New Delhi, Sunday. MEA

the two sides had agreed to the BRICS joint declaration adopted on Saturday, which acknowledged the sensibilities of both sides.

"We had a good conversation with the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, and agreed to put the past behind us and look to the future," Pezeshkian said at the conclusion of his visit to India, according to a statement by the Iranian Embassy in India.

"We also had discussions with the Presidents of Russia and China, which were mostly

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and Deputy CM Eknath Shinde in Mumbai, Sunday. AKASH PATIL

## Uniform Civil Code in all 21 NDA states before 2029: Shah

Express News Service  
Mumbai, September 13

THE UNIFORM Civil Code will be implemented across all NDA-ruled states before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Sunday.

Speaking to reporters in Mumbai, Shah said, "Some states have introduced UCC. It is our resolve to enforce UCC in all 21 BJP-led NDA-ruled states before 2029 Lok Sabha polls."

Responding to other questions, Shah said the "Government is discussing with its alliance partners and various groups" on the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Manipur.

Listing the Government's "major reforms", he said, "Our Government abolished Triple Talaq, which gave equal rights to Muslim women. We scrapped Article 370 without shedding a drop of blood and

firing a bullet. Kashmir is an integral part of India."

Shah said, "In the last 12 years, the BJP-led NDA government has pushed major reforms on many fronts, including social, economic and criminal justice. The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been effectively enforced. The rate of conviction recorded in one year is 30 per cent."

He said, "We have ruthlessly tackled Naxalism and adopted a zero-tolerance policy on terrorism... Whether it was the surgical strikes or Operation Sindoor, it showed the Government's grit and determination to fight enemies without compromise."

Speaking about the drive against illegal immigrants, Shah said, "All I can say is we will identify each and every individual who has illegally sneaked inside. We will nab and deport illegal Bangladeshis. This much is for sure."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

### Pushing UCC, state by state

Amit Shah's announcement underlines the BJP's shift from a national push for UCC to a state-led approach — a line the Sangh Parivar expressed in 2022-23 — with Uttarakhand's code, in force since last year, as the template. Gujarat, Assam and MP have followed with similar legislation; MP's Bill is awaiting assent. All four state laws ban polygamy, require marriage registration, standardise divorce and in-

heritance rules, grant women equal inheritance rights, and mandate registration of live-in

relationships. Uttarakhand allows deregistration and recognises children from live-in relationships while Assam penalises non-

registration. Responding to RSS concerns, all four laws exclude STs, with Uttarakhand and Assam adding protections for specific tribal customs.

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 14~09~2026

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## Modi flags ‘weaponisation’ of tech

full member countries as well as its partner countries, Modi said the trust of Global South countries in BRICS has grown because their voices are heard and their experiences are respected.

He said that with rising global tensions impacting lives, the emphasis is on enhancing resilience within the bloc. In this context, he announced a slew of initiatives -- BRICS Integrated Early Warning System for prevention of and response to infectious diseases, BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Cooperation Framework, BRICS Incubator Network, Startup Innovation Fund, BRICS MSME Cooperation Portal, Digital Centre of Excellence for Smart Grids and Energy Storage, Urban Mobility Hub, and Centres of Excellence for Agro-Ecology and Regenerative Agriculture.

"The BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture will create new opportunities for farmers. Through this initiative, AI, geospatial technology, and Digital Public Infrastructure will be connected to the real needs of farmers. The weaponisation of technology and critical minerals can hinder our shared progress. Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in the adoption of technology," he said.

"I can say from personal experience that the trust of Global South nations in BRICS has grown, because within BRICS, their voices are heard. Their experiences are respected. And solutions are created with them, not merely for them," he said.

Framing the global situation, he said: "Tensions across the

world are constantly rising, having a significant negative and far-reaching impact on the lives of ordinary people... Pandemics, climate disasters, and supply-chain disruptions have demonstrated that in today's interconnected world, no crisis remains confined to a single region. That is why we have placed special emphasis on enhancing resilience within the BRICS group. Identifying challenges in time, preparing for them, and taking immediate action are equally essential," he said.

"With this mindset, a consensus has been reached on a BRICS Integrated Early Warning System for the prevention of and response to infectious diseases. Guidelines for Early Warning Data Integration regarding disaster management have been formulated. The BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Cooperation Framework will help make our supply chains more reliable and resilient," he said.

"Today, this hall brings together diverse continents, cultures and developmental journeys. This stands as a testament to the growing strength, appeal, and unprecedented trust associated with BRICS... The strength of BRICS lies in our diversity and cooperation," he said.

"Under India's chairmanship, we have focused all our efforts on four pillars: Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability. I am pleased that, with your cooperation and support, we have been able to transform our shared vision into a win-win collaboration," Modi said.

"By advancing along these

four pillars, we have endeavored to foster inclusive global growth through BRICS. This is because we believe that the benefits of solutions developed within BRICS should not be limited to the bloc alone; they should be made adaptable and accessible to meet the needs of the Global South," he said.

Under the pillar of innovation, he said the BRICS Incubator Network would connect start-ups and incubators. "We have proposed a BRICS Startup Innovation Fund to promote innovative and scalable solutions," Modi said.

Underlining that India has advanced the spirit of friendship, partnership, and cooperation through the BRICS platform, Modi said, "We have endeavored to ensure that BRICS cooperation is not limited to governments alone; we want our entrepreneurs, farmers, researchers, women, youth, and ordinary citizens to become active participants as well."

### ***Xi's 5-point plan***

Elaborating on the open-source AI proposal, Xi, in his address, said: "China will be a pioneer in establishing a BRICS AI open-source community, support cooperation in developing and applying large language models, hold specialised AI seminars and training courses, and build an open ecosystem for AI."

China has partnered with around 30 countries to establish the World AI Cooperation Organisation. Beijing is focusing on establishing a cost-effective international AI ecosystem based on open models, unlike major

US developers such as OpenAI and Anthropic, which rely on closed frameworks.

The five-point initiative, Xi said, is aimed at boosting cooperation in manufacturing, trade and technology across member states. The initiative focuses on establishing an inclusive artificial intelligence framework, facilitating trade and investment, deepening digital industry ties, advancing "intelligent manufacturing," and launching a joint science and technology development initiative.

In his remarks, Xi said that BRICS should leverage its close ties with emerging markets and the Global South to safeguard supply chains and build a large integrated market.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry statement quoted Xi as saying in his address that "a world without rules is like a crossroads without traffic lights, where chaos and disorder are all but guaranteed. Fairness and justice is a universal aspiration, and international rules must be written by all countries".

"The world is currently undergoing profound changes, a phenomenon unseen in a century, with the Global South rising collectively and becoming a key driving force for multipolarity. At the same time, the international situation is complex and volatile, with various risks and challenges emerging one after another. To stabilise and improve the world, the BRICS countries must seize the initiative in history, unite with the vast majority of the Global South countries, play a positive, stabilising, and benevolent role in international affairs, and enhance the common well-being of humanity," he said, according to the statement.

"Xi Jinping emphasised that the Global South should jointly uphold the rule of international law, safeguard the basic norms of international relations such as sovereign equality, non-interference in internal affairs, and peaceful settlement of disputes, and ensure the equal application of international law and rules without double standards... accelerate the formation of a broadly consensus-based global artificial intelligence governance framework, allowing emerging technologies to illuminate the path to common prosperity," the statement said.

Also addressing the session, Putin said: "As global challenges keep surfacing, we should adopt a holistic approach to address both the symptoms and root causes. Global South countries should jointly advance better (global) governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats."

"Many around the world find our core values and ideals appealing, including our commitment to charting an independent course and a desire to resolve problems collectively, guided by international law and the key provisions of the UN Charter," he said.

South Africa President Cyril Ramaphosa, Egypt President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, Indonesia President Prabowo Subianto, Ethiopia Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, foreign ministers from Brazil and Saudi Arabia, leaders or representatives of BRICS partner countries and guest countries, and heads of international organisations like UN Secretary-General António Guterres were among those who attended the outreach summit on Sunday.

## Shah on UCC

Asked about the anti-drug Nasha Mukht Abhiyan, the Home Minister said, "I will visit each and every state to ensure the campaign percolates to the grassroots. We have to get rid of this menace. I am confident India will succeed in eliminating this drug menace."

Shah also announced a month-long mass outreach campaign, Seva Sankalp Abhiyan, to be held from September 17, which is the birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, to October 17 to convey the "message of good governance". The event will also mark Modi's "25 years of public service as Gujarat CM and PM," he said.

"We will take this campaign to every district, Lok Sabha and Assembly constituencies, and polling booths at the grassroots," Shah said.

Earlier, Shah inaugurated a specially curated exhibition of manuscripts, "Shri Ganesh Dnyanarati", at the Asiatic Society of Mumbai. Addressing the gathering, Shah said, "Knowledge cannot become a prisoner to any ideology. If you try to bind it in any form, you distort its very purpose. Knowledge should be uninhibited."

Speaking at the Gems & Jewellery Awards at BKC, Shah said, "India should lead the lab-grown diamond sector in the world... Knowing the potential of the sector, the Government is planning to invest Rs 50,000 crore in the gems and jewellery industry, which is rooted in tradition and culture." A new gem and jewellery bourse is being built in Jaipur, he said.

## Iran-UAE consensus

meeting, from May 11-13, a diplomat said there had been a "vibe shift," with the "Iranians and Emiratis" unable to "see eye-to-eye." At the Foreign Ministers' meeting days later, on May 14-15, all that could be put on record was a statement noting "differing views among some members" over West Asia, with members expressing their "respective national positions." Nothing more.

Then the Indian team got to work. BRICS Sherpa Sudhakar Dalela, assisted by Sous Sherpa Shambhu Lingappa Hakki, along with Joint Secretaries Rajiv Bodwade and Dr Basir Ahmad and Director Mini Devi Kumam, began reaching out to counterparts in other member countries — drawing on Dalela's background in trade and economic policy, Hakki's stint in China and fluency in Mandarin. Behind them was the wider expertise of officials at the Multilateral Economic Relations (MER) wing of the Ministry of External Affairs.

The 60-day ceasefire between the US and Iran, before it lapsed in August, opened a window of opportunity. Indian officials began reaching out to the UAE and Iran to press the case for a BRICS consensus. Prime

Minister Narendra Modi and UAE ruler Mohamed bin Zayed spoke during Modi's visit to the UAE on May 15; Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian spoke to Modi on June 22, when the consensus issue also came up.

In parallel, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar spoke to his counterparts in Iran and the UAE, while NSA Ajit Doval reached out to his counterparts during the BRICS NSAs meeting on June 22-23.

Indian Ambassador to the UAE Deepak Mittal and his counterpart in Iran, Rudra Gaurav Shresth, were asked to approach their capitals and do the spadework. Unsurprisingly, positions hardened on both sides, with red lines firmly drawn.

Modi's visit to Bishkek for the SCO leaders' summit from August 30 to September 1 offered a chance to meet Pezeshkian. It is learnt he was told that as a new BRICS member — Iran and the UAE joined in 2024 — it would not reflect well if the grouping failed to reach consensus, and that since this would be his first visit to India, he should be part of a "successful" summit.

The groundwork had already been laid by Dalela's team in negotiations with the Iranian

Sherpa, but Tehran wanted the matter raised at the leaders' level. Pezeshkian's team said he would revert after consulting the top leadership, particularly the IRGC and Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, who have the final word on foreign and strategic policy in wartime.

Within days, Tehran responded it was willing to go the extra mile, since it should not be blamed for a war started by the Americans. This was the first breakthrough, sources said.

That gave momentum to talks with the UAE, which had been less enthusiastic. Sherpas worked overtime in the final days: sentences and paragraphs were projected on a screen in Delhi as they argued over formulations. Changes were made, suggestions struck down or accepted, and any sentence lacking consensus was flagged in square brackets — removed as agreement was reached. Central to the consensus was that neither the US nor Iran could be named.

China and Russia stepped in as well in the final countdown, with Brazil and Egypt playing a supporting role with both sides. "The Iranians had come around, but the Chinese and Russians leaned on the UAE to sign off on the language," a diplomat said.

Hanging over the talks was the possibility of no joint declaration at all. "That would have

been portrayed by Western countries as a failure. So it was in the interest of both UAE and Iran, and China and Russia helped in convincing them," the diplomat said.

All of this led to Paragraph 28: "We express deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in Middle East/West Asia and, recalling our respective national positions, call for exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation."

The declaration, accepted by both the UAE and Iran, acknowledged the sensitivities of each side by flagging territorial sovereignty and the need to protect civilian lives and infrastructure — a nod to the UAE, which has faced Iranian strikes on its cities, with Tehran calling it a proxy of the United States.

"We urge to ensure the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure in accordance with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations in their entirety and interconnectedness, including respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the States," the declaration said. "We encourage increasing efforts, through dialogue and diplomacy, towards a long-term understanding that will contribute to lasting peace, security and stability in the region. We stress the need to work together

to maintain smooth flow of global trade, supply chains and energy, in accordance with applicable international law."

Unlike the G20 declaration of September 2023, New Delhi did not have a large, dedicated secretariat this time. Back then, former bureaucrat Amitabh Kant, as G20 Sherpa, led talks with a high-profile team of diplomats on deputation to the secretariat.

This time, the negotiating team was essentially the MER division of the MEA, led by Secretary (Economic Relations) Dalela. Of the 12 diplomats and officials in the 31-member division, five played key roles:

**Sudhakar Dalela**, BRICS Sherpa — a 1993-batch IFS officer who began his career in Tel Aviv and speaks Hebrew. He has served in missions in Brasilia, Chicago, Dhaka, Geneva, Thimphu and Washington DC, and was Ambassador to Bhutan (2022-2025). He was also Director in Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's Office (2009-2011), Director (Trade Policy), and twice served at India's Permanent Mission to the WTO, including as Deputy Permanent Representative (2014-2016). In the US, he was Consul General in Chicago, Minister for Political Affairs (2011-2014), and Deputy Chief of Mission (2020-2022).

**Shambhu Lingappa Hakki**, Sous Sherpa and Joint

Secretary (MER & G20) — a career diplomat who joined the Foreign Service in 2008 and served as Consul General in Guangzhou (2021-25), besides postings in Beijing and Washington. Fluent in Mandarin, he also runs a YouTube channel with over 60 videos of him performing various ragas.

**Dr Basir Ahmed**, Joint Secretary, MER division — a 2009-batch IFS officer and a doctor by training, who was Deputy Chief of Mission in Indonesia and served at India's Permanent Mission in Geneva.

**Rajiv Bodwade**, Joint Secretary, MER division — a 2009-batch IFS officer who was Deputy Chief of Mission in Israel during the October 7 attacks and has served as Deputy Chief of Protocol in Delhi.

**Mini Devi Kumam**, Director, MER division — a 2011-batch IFS officer who has served in Vietnam and at India's Permanent Mission in Geneva.

On his YouTube channel, Hakki writes: "A practitioner of Hindustani classical music, I have been drawn towards music, which is a universal language and transcends all barriers. The music I create has its roots in Indian classical music, but has also imbibed certain aspects of Western music." In the end, it was this, transcending barriers with a common language, that struck the right diplomatic chord.

West Asia had divided Iran and the UAE over the last six months. In May this year, when BRICS foreign ministers met in New Delhi, Russia's Sergey Lavrov had told the UAE and Iranian ministers to hold direct talks.

Now, with direct talks happening between the two sides, there is a possibility that it may lead to more peace moves.

## Pezeshkian

brief exchanges. A promising outlook for the expansion of economic cooperation is taking shape," he said.

Pezeshkian's remarks offer the first possible window of opportunity for the two warring

sides to sit down and talk, and move towards de-escalating the tension in the region.

The Crown Prince is the eldest son of UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

The meeting came days before scheduled talks between Iran and members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) in Oman on September 14 to discuss an agreement on transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

In the joint declaration on Saturday, the BRICS leaders expressed "deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions

in West Asia and, "recalling our respective national positions", called for "exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation."

The declaration acknowledged the sensibilities of both sides by flagging territorial sovereignty and the need to secure civilians and infrastructure.

UAE has been at the receiving end of a series of Iranian strikes on its cities with Tehran calling it a proxy of the US.

In addition, the declaration underscored dialogue and diplomacy and smooth flow of energy -- all important issues and challenges faced by the developing countries.

The phrasing of the war in

# Censured by HC, Noida DM moves SC against order quashing student NSA case

"Preventing people from gathering in public spaces or agitating their rights on the grounds of assumed breach of peace, would be throwing the baby out of the bath water. If such a view is taken by the state and approved of by the courts, it would lead to a cessation of the collective expression of opinion in public spaces," the ruling said.

# Life (& death) in a student ghetto



PHOTO: ABHINAV SAHA

Over the last three decades, Satya Niketan has transformed into a dense hub of private accommodations, catering to thousands of students from all over India enrolled in DU's South Campus. They chase a dream. But sometimes, like it happened a week ago, these dreams die suddenly. SOPHIYA MATHEW and SUKRITA BARUAH visited the cramped lanes to get a sense of life.

LOOKING BACK to his days as an undergraduate student at Sri Venkateswara College nearly three decades ago, Ravi Vajala clearly remembers the settlement opposite the college gate. He recalls a couple of shops that sold patties and cheap burgers, which students frequented.

Anshuman Kishore, who went to Sri Venkateswara in the early 1990s, remembers being introduced to "Campa-Doodh" — an odd concoction of milk, Campa Cola and ice — there, sold at a shop with three stools and a rickety table out front, with music played on a cassette player by a *halwai* next door.

In Vajala's memory, the colony was a residential area with a handful of small shops, where families lived in houses that were two or perhaps three storeys tall, lining bumpy, stone-paved lanes that were wide enough for a Maruti to squeeze through but not much else. Vajala is today the principal of Sri Venkateswara College. And the settlement into which he would sometimes wander as a student has transformed into a densely packed hub of private student accommodation — where residents include many students of his college who have come from states across the country to study in Delhi.

Each building in Satya Niketan begins where the next one ends. They are narrow and tall, most are at least four storeys high. Almost every building seems to offer paying guest (PG) accommodation for students who study in the Delhi University's South Campus colleges in the vicinity.

The compact neighbourhood is structured almost entirely around the lives of these students; its microeconomy is driven by the young adults who have made the capital their temporary home.

There are messes that serve Rs-90 meals, shops that offer photocopying services and give computer printouts, reading rooms where students pay to sit with books because their rooms are too small or too crowded, stalls that sell tea, momos, or rolls, and small cafes with more ambitious menus.

Shops and offices of property dealers and brokers are everywhere, promising to find just the right PG for the needs and budget of every student.

A week ago, a five-storey building housing one such PG came crashing down, crushing seven people under bricks and concrete, including five students of nearby colleges.

A crackdown by civic authorities against illegal constructions and dangerous buildings across Delhi followed. In Satya Niketan itself, at least one other building that was deemed unsafe was demolished, and many others were sealed. Many of the students who lived in the PGs packed their bags and left, shaken.

## A neighbourhood and a university

The evolution of Satya Niketan over the 30-35 years since Vajala and Kishore went to Venky into one of Delhi's most prominent student ghettos is closely tied to the



A five-storey building came crashing down on September 6 in Satya Niketan area.

ABHINAV SAHA

expansion of DU's South Campus, the enormous influx of outstation students to a university that is desperately short of facilities to house them, and the alacrity with which a variety of entrepreneurs have rushed to cash in on the opportunity and Satya Niketan's fortuitous location.

The settlement at the corner of Ring Road and Benito Juarez Marg close to Dhaura Kuan emerged in the 1960s as part of a Jhuggi Jhopri Removal scheme of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA). People who had been evicted from slums on government land were allotted plots up to 40 square metres in the area.

These original allottees were not allowed to transfer their plots, but many did it anyway, using well-worn workarounds such as "agreements" and "power of attorney". But the new occupants had no legal title to the plots, and were treated as unauthorised occupants.

Then, on October 11, 1972, the DDA's Slum and JJ Department decided to regularise the occupation by offering perpetual leasehold rights at Rs 125 per sq yard, along with a 10% penalty and annual ground rent equal to 2.5% of the premium from the date of occupation.

"The decision of 1972 was a welfare measure intended to give benefit to those who were otherwise in breach of law," the High Court noted in a later judgement (2011). There are 299 plots in the area.

The lanes get even more cramped as they lead from Satya Niketan to the adjoining urban village of Moti Bagh, where the houses are even smaller. Fifty-seven-year-old Ved Prakash, who has lived all his life in Moti Bagh, described the transformation of the locality next to his own.

"The original allottees (of Satya Niketan) mostly sold their plots and left, and mainly Punjabi and Bania families moved in. Those families started a small market

in the 18 plots at the front of the locality (facing Venky). These were small shops like a grocery store, vegetable shops, a salon, and tea stalls. The rest of the neighbourhood remained residential," he said.

A resident of Satya Niketan who declined to be identified by name said his family, who lived in Karol Bagh, had bought their plot from an original allottee because they wanted to live in a quieter locality.

Chandni Singh, who runs a salon in the area, recalled having grown up in a locality that was greener and had a more closely knit residential character.

"Earlier, we would sit out on *charpais*. The lanes were wider and more open. What you see now is unrecognizable from what used to be," she said.

Singh, Ved Prakash, and a number of other long-time residents linked the transformation of the area to the coming of the PGs phenomenon. From the beginning of the 2000s, they said, homeowners started to turn rooms of their houses into private hostels, and charged each tenant individually. From the 2010s onward, the PG business exploded.

Through this period, Delhi University too underwent massive expansion. In 1960, there were 26 affiliated to the university, in which about 14,000 students studied. Delhi's first Master Plan, prepared in 1962, noted that these colleges were overcrowded and unable to cope with the increasing demand for college education. These colleges were also largely concentrated in North Delhi, and the Master Plan noted that students had to travel long distances from "far-flung colonies" to attend classes.

Thus, the Master Plan said, "A university centre in the south is proposed near the junction of Kitchener Road (today's Sardar Patel Marg) and Ring Road. This centre will have several colleges. It is also

## How much are students spending

● **Kim**, 2nd year student, Jesus and Mary College  
**PG:** ₹12,500/ month  
**ELECTRICITY:** ₹14 per unit  
**COOKING GAS:** ₹100/ month  
**FOOD:** ₹4,000-₹5,000/ month

● **Manthan**, 3rd year student, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College  
**1-ROOM FLAT WITH TWO BEDS:** ₹8,500 a bed/ month  
**FOOD (FROM MESS):** ₹5,700/ month  
**ELECTRICITY:** ₹1,000/ month

● **Neha**, graduate, Motilal Nehru College  
**PG, SATYA NIKETAN:** ₹9,000 per bed/ month  
**ELECTRICITY:** ₹2,000/ month  
**FOOD:** ₹3,500/ month  
**SECURITY:** Rs 22,000 (deposit per year; not refunded)

● **Alumnus**, Janki Devi Memorial College  
**ONE TIME CHARGE FOR KRISHNA HOSTEL (ON-CAMPUS):** ₹10,000  
**MESS CHARGES:** ₹42,000  
**HOSTEL CHARGES OTHER THAN MESS:** ₹1,08,000  
**TOTAL FEES:** ₹1,60,000



A narrow corridor at a PG in Satya Niketan.

EXPRESS

proposed to have a number of colleges within easy reach of the residential areas each to serve a population of about 1,50,000... It is proposed that only a few of these colleges would have hostel and dormitory facilities, as most of the students served by the colleges would come from the surrounding residential areas."

This was the broad context in which DU's South Campus was planned. It was developed in the 1970s, and moved to its present location in 1984. Today, there are 13 colleges in South Campus, including Sri Venkateswara, Motilal Nehru, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma, Ram Lal Anand, Maitreyi, Jesus and Mary, Aryabhata, and Gargi — many of them within walking distance from Satya Niketan.

Unlike what the Master Plan had envisioned though, these colleges began to attract students from across the country. By the 2010s, students from outside Delhi accounted for as much as 70% of the strength in DU's premier colleges. Vajala estimates that more than 60% of the current student population at Sri Venkateswara is from outside Delhi.

"I could see a visible sudden surge of outstation students after 2010. This could be because of many reasons, including the growing gap between state and central universities, and the craze for IAS coaching in Delhi," he said.

A resident of the area who did not want to be named recalled that back in the 1990s, his family rented out a two-bedroom apartment in their building to a family for Rs 5,000. "When more students began looking for places to stay, families rented out rooms and floors to them. But soon, they realized that the PG model was more profitable than residential rentals," the resident said.

So, "Instead of renting out floors, people started to convert the space into

multiple rooms, each with multiple beds, and rented out individual beds. The number of floors also began to grow," he said.

While the recent tragedy has put the vertical expansion of this area under the scanner, unauthorised construction was already being recorded in the colony by 1991. In 1992, the government told Rajya Sabha that eight properties in the area had been sealed since January 1991.

According to information provided by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the violations included unauthorised construction of rooms, toilets, and staircases on the first, second and third floors, as well as the construction of illegal basements.

## Rs 8,000 for a bed and shared loo; food and electricity extra

A five-storey building in the area, with one of its walls comprised almost entirely of blue-tinted glass panelling, has nothing that identifies it as a commercial 'PG' accommodation. There is no signboard of any kind — even though everyone knows what the building is.

"You won't find anything cheaper this close to South Campus," the PG owner said. The owner's family lives on the first floor; the other floors have rows of rooms that operate as PGs.

Each floor has a narrow, dimly-lit corridor with doors leading to three rooms. A room on the second floor has three small beds and a shared attached bathroom. Students pay Rs 8,000 per month for a bed here. The room is tiny; the three beds leave barely enough floor space to walk past suitcases, clothes, and study tables.

"Electricity is extra, on a sub-meter. If you want food, mess charges are separate," the owner said. "That is Rs 3,500 a month for two daily meals. It is simple home-style food — dal, sabzi, roti."

If students cook their own food, they have to share the cost of gas cylinder refills. But cylinders are difficult to get, and have to be bought on the black market for prices that can be unpredictable.

A door in the room with the three beds leads to what is described as a "balcony", but from where nothing but the grey wall of the next building is visible. There is a common kitchen on the floor, with a stove and a water dispenser. The area under the sink is crowded with 20-litre bubble-top water containers, both full and empty.

Amlan Das, who came to study in Delhi from Assam, lived in Satya Niketan for a year in 2012 when he was an undergraduate student at Delhi College of Arts and Commerce. He found a broker who got him a room for Rs 8,000 a month.

"They called it a PG, but I had to buy my own bed, arrange my own food. But I had no choice. I was new and didn't know my way around, and my first priority was to get settled within my means. This place was the closest to college and offered student-friendly facilities," he said.

But Das could not stay for long. He found the area suffocating and cramped, and moved to Lajpat Nagar after a year.

A week after the building collapse, its shadow hung over Satya Niketan like invisible construction dust. Young women walked in and out of their "PGs", watchmen at the gates looked closely at strangers. Asked if a PG operated in their building, a couple of them said No reflexively.

But the student housing business was carrying on.



# BRICS Summit

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 14, 2026

{ INDIA 2026 }



Prime Minister Narendra Modi along with heads of state and government at the BRICS Leaders' Summit in New Delhi on Sunday. The leaders in the front row include (from left) Kazakhstan President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. REUTERS

## Trade, defence in focus as PM meets leaders of Egypt, Indonesia, S Africa

Divya A

New Delhi, September 13

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday held bilateral discussions with South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi and a host of other visiting leaders on the sidelines of the BRICS Leaders' Summit, with a focus on boosting trade and investment ties.

With Egypt emerging as a critically important partner for India in West Asian and North African dynamics, Modi and El-Sisi discussed regional issues and trade ties. In a social media post, PM Modi said that he had a "wonderful interaction" with President El-Sisi. "We talked about various issues, notably regional issues and the India-Egypt friendship that is significantly growing in recent times," he said.

This was among the 15 bilateral meetings that the Prime Minister had with visiting leaders over the last three days. Other meetings on Sunday included those with Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, Burundi President Évariste Ndayishimiye, Ugandan Vice President Jessica Alupo, and Nigerian Vice President Kashim Shettima.

Officials said boosting cooperation in trade, investment, defence and people-to-people ties was a dominant theme at the meetings. In a social media post, PM Modi said he and Ramaphosa reviewed the full breadth of the India-South Af-



Egypt's President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi departs from New Delhi after conclusion of the BRICS Summit on Sunday. PTI

rica strategic partnership, including cooperation in mining and critical minerals, infrastructure, food security, digital public infrastructure and emerging technologies.

"Our partnership is rooted in history and firmly focused on the future. We will work closely for Africa's progress, the priorities of the Global South and a more balanced global order," he said. The Ministry of External Affairs said the two leaders exchanged views on a range of global issues of mutual interest and agreed to maintain close coordination in multilateral fora.

During his meeting with Burundi President Ndayishimiye, who is also the Chairperson of the African Union, PM Modi reaffirmed the importance of the India-African Union partnership as a key pillar of cooperation within the Global South and discussed the early convening of the 4th India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS-IV).

The two leaders recalled In-

dia's role in bringing the African Union into the G20 fold during India's presidency in 2023, and stressed that the India-African Union partnership is a key pillar of cooperation within the Global South.

The Prime Minister also met Nigerian Vice President Kashim Shettima to discuss a more representative, inclusive and multi-polar international order as they reviewed the multifaceted relationship between the two countries. Their discussions covered trade and investment, defence and security, energy partnership, agriculture, health and digital technologies.

Meanwhile, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Sunday held talks with his Saudi Arabian counterpart Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud and discussed the West Asia conflict as well as reviewed bilateral ties. The Saudi Foreign Minister was in New Delhi to attend the final day's session of the BRICS Summit.



## BRICS Brothers

(From left) BRICS Foreign Ministers Wang Yi (China), S Jaishankar (India), Mukhtar Tileuberdi (Kazakhstan), Badr Abdelatty (Egypt), Sugiono (Indonesia), Sergey Lavrov (Russia), and Abbas Araghchi (Iran) during the summit in New Delhi. @DRSJAISHANKAR/X

## Putin pitches for grain market, insurance

Press Trust of India

New Delhi, September 13

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin on Sunday proposed a new insurance mechanism and a collaborative initiative for the grain market among the BRICS nations as he called upon the grouping to adopt a holistic approach in combating pressing global challenges.

Putin proposed the new initiatives for economic growth among the BRICS member na-

tions as well as the Global South nations amid sanctions imposed by the Western powers on Moscow for its war on Ukraine.

The G7, the EU, and the UK prohibited Western companies from insuring any ship transporting Russian crude unless the oil was purchased at or below a specified price cap. The sanctions relating to insurance sector have adversely impacted Russian crude oil exports.

Putin also pitched for setting up a dedicated platform for

economic growth with the BRICS. "We have independent routes for moving capital, labour and technologies. In fact, we can operate regardless of outside pressure," Putin said at the BRICS concluding session.

"We have some promising initiatives going forward, such as creating an insurance mechanism and a grain market. These are Russian proposals, and we invite all other member states to make use of those," he said.

Putin also complimented the

functioning of the New Development Bank, saying it is handling projects worth \$140 billion. NDB is a multilateral development bank established by BRICS nations. "As global challenges keep surfacing, we should adopt a holistic approach to address both the symptoms and root causes," Putin said. "Global South countries should jointly advance better (global) governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats," he said.

## Members call for cooperation over pathogen research, access

Anonna Dutt

New Delhi, September 13

THE NEW Delhi Declaration calls for constructive engagement in negotiations for the Pathogen Access and Benefit Sharing Annex to the WHO pandemic agreement "while reaffirming sovereign rights of States over their biological resources as well as the sovereign right to legislate and implement laws, including national access and benefit-sharing legislation".

Amid Covid-19 pandemic, the WHO planned to develop a legally binding pandemic agreement for better response to any future pandemic. While the agreement was adopted during last year's World Health Assembly, one annex continues to hold the agreement hostage. Once an agreement is reached on the Pathogen Access and Benefit Sharing (PABS) Annex, the pandemic agreement can be approved or ratified by member states. PABS Annex will create a roadmap for sharing of dangerous pathogens and medicines, diagnostics or vaccines developed. Countries are yet to agree on whether sharing of pathogen samples be linked mandatorily with sharing of benefits developed.

# Defence Secy meets Vietnam Dy Defence Minister, discusses regional security

Amrita Nayak Dutta  
New Delhi, September 13

DEFENCE SECRETARY Rajesh Kumar Singh and Senior Lieutenant General Nguyen Truong Thang, the Deputy Minister of National Defence of Vietnam, on Sunday discussed advancing regional security and deepening the bilateral Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, while also strengthening the friendship between India and Vietnam. This meeting followed a high-level discussion between the Prime Ministers of both countries on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit. In a statement issued on Sunday, the Ministry of Defence said the discussions centred on accelerating joint initiatives, technology sharing and defence industrial collaboration. The two sides reaffirmed their shared commitment to expanding maritime and defence ties to ensure a peaceful, stable, and rule-based regional security architecture, it noted. “Both sides reaffirmed their joint commitment to enhanc-

ing practical defence cooperation through ASEAN-led mechanisms, noting that collaborative platforms like the ADMM-Plus Experts’ Working Groups are vital for maintaining regional stability and building collective security architectures in the Indo-Pacific,” the statement noted. They agreed on the scheduled conduct of the next Defence Policy Dialogue to be hosted in India on the sidelines of Aero India 2027. The Ministry of Defence statement noted that the interaction underscores the growing momentum in defence ties between India and Vietnam, building directly on the strategic vision set forth by both Prime Ministers at the BRICS summit. Over the last few years, the defence cooperation between India and Vietnam has deepened substantially. This includes Defence Policy Dialogues, military-to-military exchanges, high-level visits, capacity building and training programmes, cooperation in UN Peacekeeping, ship visits and bilateral exercises between the countries.

# UN chief backs demand for expanding Security Council

Divya A  
New Delhi, September 13

SPEAKING AT the BRICS Summit on Sunday, United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres backed the demand from the Global South to expand the UN Security Council, which, he said, will help “bring balance and equity to global systems and institutions”. He also underlined that India has been at the forefront of this demand. Emphasising that today’s economic, demographic and geopolitical realities are not those of 1945, Guterres said that “the institutional structures must reflect it”. Prime Minister Narendra Modi had on Saturday pitched for a greater role for developing countries in global decision-making, saying the Global South should move from being a “rule-taker” to “rule-shaper”. Echoing that sentiment, Guterres said: “Countries represented at this Summit speak to that changing reality.” Over the past several years, he said, major emerging nations have called for an expansion of the UN Security Council. “India has been at the forefront of this



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Secretary-General of the United Nations António Guterres at Bharat Mandapam on the second day of the BRICS Leaders’ Summit in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

demand,” Guterres said. He also weighed in on how the world is increasingly moving towards multipolarity, adding that it “helps bring balance and equity to global systems and institutions”. “But this requires reforming global multilateral institutions — including the UN Security Council and the Bretton Woods system — to reflect the world of today,” he said. “As your Summit’s theme rightly frames it, we must build for resilience, innovation, co-

operation and sustainability, he said at a session on Sunday, adding that it is an imperative for “shaping inclusive global growth”. In the New Delhi Declaration issued on Saturday, China and Russia have reiterated their support for India and Brazil to play a greater role in the United Nations. According to the Declaration, the leaders of BRICS countries reiterated their support for a “comprehensive reform of the UN, including its Security Council”.

The Declaration pressed for the need to make the UN body “more democratic, representative, effective and efficient, and to increase the representation of developing countries in the Council’s membership so that it can adequately respond to prevailing global challenges and support the legitimate aspirations of emerging and developing countries from Africa, Asia and Latin America, including BRICS countries, to play a greater role in international affairs, in particular in the UN, including its Security Council”. The UN Security Council has five permanent members — China, France, Russia, the UK and the US. Each permanent member holds veto power over resolutions. This number has remained unchanged since the Council’s inception in 1945. Guterres also spelt out an agenda for the world facing a geopolitical flux. “First — through financing... Multilateral Development Banks must also become bigger, better and bolder, with a new business model to mobilise massive private investment and expand concessional funding to developing countries,” he said.

# Defence to space, trade to tech: India, Philippines to deepen ties

Divya A  
New Delhi, September 13

A YEAR after New Delhi and Manila elevated their ties to a strategic partnership, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Philippines President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr held wide-ranging discussions on Sunday, on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit, on further advancing the ties. Modi also welcomed Manila’s decision to join the India-led Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI). Marcos Jr, who visited New Delhi in August last year, at-

tended the BRICS Summit as the current ASEAN chair. His visit assumes significance in the context of India’s Act East policy and its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with ASEAN. India and the Philippines have rapidly strengthened their diplomatic, economic and security ties in recent times, with the 2022 deal to supply BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles to the Philippine Navy marking a major milestone. Both countries hold regular staff talks for their Army, Navy and Air Force to improve joint security cooperation. Mean-

while, trade has grown past \$3 billion, driven by Indian pharmaceutical exports, IT services and agricultural cooperation. In a statement after the bilateral meeting, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the two leaders expressed satisfaction at the progress made in bilateral cooperation and agreed to deepen and expand collaboration across a wide range of areas, including defence and security, trade and investment, space, railway infrastructure, fintech, education, tourism, science and technology, innovation and people-to-people ties. “De-



Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr at the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, Sunday. REUTERS

lighted to meet President Ferdinand Marcos Jr on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit. Wished

him a very happy birthday too. We reviewed the growing momentum in the India-Philippines Strategic Partnership,” Modi said in a post on X. “Key focus areas are: Economic linkages. Technology. Trade. Space. Innovation. Creative industry. We also discussed ways to further strengthen India-ASEAN engagement,” he said. The two leaders also exchanged views on regional and global issues of mutual interest and reiterated their commitment to strengthening cooperation across all areas of the stra-

tegic partnership. Following Marcos Jr’s visit last year, India and the Philippines had adopted a 2025-29 roadmap to expand military training, staff talks, and maritime security cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region. Both sides are driven by shared concerns over China’s aggressive territorial assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific and the South China Sea. India has consistently supported a rules-based maritime order in the South China Sea, based on international law and the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

# El Niño to peak during Oct-Dec this year, says US climate agency

**Express News Service**  
*Bengaluru, September 13*

THE CURRENT El Niño event is all set to enter its peak phase during October-December this year, US-based National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) has warned.

El Niño is a naturally occurring ocean-atmospheric phenomenon, wherein there is an abnormal warming recorded along the equatorial and central Pacific Ocean waters. El Niño conditions are often linked to extreme weather across the globe, in the form of higher-than-average temperatures, rainfall or droughts. The 2026 El Niño would be a historic event ever recorded since 1950.

“As a result of this, there are higher chances of experiencing impacts consistent with El Niño,” NOAA said. In August, the sea surface temperatures continued to rise and the key Niño regions clocked temperatures ranging between 1.8 to 3 degrees Celsius.

The latest Niño index (June through August) was 1.4 degrees Celsius, up by 0.4 degrees Celsius from May-July, confirming the rapidly intensifying event.

The agency added there is a greater than 90 per cent chance that the current El Niño would further intensify into the 'very strong' category and prevail through the winter season.

● KOLHAPUR DISTRICT DISASTER MANAGEMENT AUTHORITY HAS TRAINED 15 TRANSWOMEN SO FAR

## From hiding identity to pulling people to safety: Meet the transwomen rescue squad

**Shubham Kurale**  
*Pune, September 13*

IN THE last week of August, a group of people gathered at Rajaram Lake, pulled on orange life jackets, checked their ropes, and spent 10 days practising rescue drills in the water. It looked like routine disaster-response training — until you learned who they were. They are part of the transgender disaster management and rescue team, for whom the life jacket has come to mean something far bigger than safety gear.

### A new first

The Kolhapur District Disaster Management Authority has trained over 2,500 volunteers in the last decade. In 2019, it created the state's first all-women rescue unit, the 'Aapda Sakhi' team, which now counts more than 500 trained volunteers. But ahead of this year's monsoon, officials decided to try something unique.

"We thought, why not train a transwomen team," said Prasad Sankpal, District Disaster Management Officer, Kolhapur. "So a first-of-its-kind transgender disaster management and rescue team initiative was begun in the country."

The first batch of 10 transwomen, all associated with the Kolhapur-based Maitri NGO, went through their inaugural training module from May 26 to 28. Since then, the district has trained 15 transwomen in total, with fresh rounds of practice held every three months — the most recent a 10-day exercise at Rajaram Lake in the last week of August.

Recruits learned rescue



Aboard a motorboat during a training exercise. EXPRESS

swimming, how to operate an inflatable rescue boat, dry and wet lifesaving techniques, motorboat handling and maintenance, and First Aid and CPR.

"So far the results are excellent," Sankpal said. "The institutional strengthening is already visible — the volunteers now help victims of road accidents without any instructions."

### More than a rescue team

For the women themselves, the initiative is about something the training manual doesn't cover.

"Even today, people see us as sex workers or beggars," said Mayuri Alvekar, founder of Maitri NGO, who brought the other volunteers on board. "I believe that such opportunities of working with the administration would help promote inclusivity and give us space in mainstream society, while changing the perspective towards us. We have been helping people during disasters or rescue needs but faced discrimination. However,

now we are getting recognition and, most importantly, an identity."

"To take the initiative further, I have also created a similar volunteer team in Dhule and Parbhani," Alvekar added.

Suhasini Devmane, another team member and Maharashtra's first transgender tourist guide, spent eight years as an ayurvedic panchakarma expert while hiding who she was.

"Despite a desire to contribute to society, many of us had previously been unable to participate in social initiatives due to a lack of opportunities," she said. "For over eight years, I had to hide my identity — else I would have lost my job, and my financial situation didn't allow for that risk then. I believe this training will not only change society's perspective towards transgender people but also boost the self-confidence of individuals within the community."

Shivani Gajabar, who is currently pursuing a Master of Social Work degree at Shivaji Uni-

versity, Kolhapur, says the acceptance hasn't fully arrived yet.

"Even today, transgender community members feel alienated from mainstream society," she said. "Though giving us a platform in the disaster management rescue team is a welcome step and would help bring inclusivity — and we all would give our best while saving lives — I feel there is a long way ahead to fill the gap. Even when I go regularly to attend classes, no one sits on my bench. I'm all alone."

Her family cut off contact when she left home in Class 7. "They used to think I could not do any considerable work," she said. "However, now, being part of the disaster management rescue team, my family members have started communicating with me again."

### What next

The administration isn't stopping at floods and drowning rescues. "There are around 30 categories of man-made and natural disasters, including wildlife rescues involving snakes and crocodiles in Kolhapur, and the transwomen volunteers will gradually be trained for these as well," Sankpal said.

One gap the authorities want to close: money. The volunteers currently work for free. "We are also planning to deploy them for crowd management during upcoming festivals such as Navaratri, Anant Chaturdashi, and the Jyotiba Yatra among others. Also, efforts are underway to grant home guard status to the transwomen volunteers, which would come with an honorarium," Sankpal told *The Indian Express*.

## Mandatory presence, no receipt for papers: Karnataka voters worry over SIR notice

**Akram M**  
*Bengaluru, September 13*

ON THE morning of September 9, a man visited the Booth Level Officer (BLO) at Ujire Gram Panchayat in Karnataka's Dakshina Kannada district with a set of documents. He was among the 1,000-odd voters in the panchayat's draft electoral roll who were served notices for identity verification during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

"The notice was issued due to the difference in my name from that in the 2002 electoral roll. Since I worked abroad, I had to add parts to my name. That is why I was served the notice," he explained.

Like elsewhere in the state, around 10 per cent of voters in the village have received similar notices. Like his father-in-law, whose initials were expanded while applying for a passport. He too visited the gram panchayat and submitted the relevant documents.

"I submitted the documents. However, there was no acknowledgement confirming that they had been accepted and that I would remain on the final electoral roll," the man told *The Indian Express*. Both men returned after being told that they would know their status when the final rolls are published on October 27.

Puttappa, a resident of the neighbouring Laila panchayat, said that his son, Suresh P, has received a notice. "He has been working abroad for the past 10 years. Now, a notice was issued regarding 'name mismatch'. When I enquired with the BLO, I was informed that my son has to be present on the date of hearing, failing which his name would be struck off," he said.

Puttappa asked how authorities could demand physical presence at a short notice. "Many, including my son, work in small companies and do not get leaves at will. How can he attend the hearing within days of

the notice being served?" he said.

While such cases reflect concerns among voters who have submitted one of the 11 documents listed by the ECI, others such as Zakariya wonder why they received notices in the first place. "According to officials, the notice was issued because the age difference between me and my grandparents was less than 40 years. However, none of my four elder brothers received a notice," he said.

Zakariya submitted his documents at Ujire panchayat last week. "If the ECI can alert us about the notice using our phone numbers, why can't it provide an acknowledgement about whether our documents have been accepted?" he asked.

Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar said there was no mechanism to inform voters in the notice phase that their documents have been accepted. "If it is accepted, they will know it on the spot," he said.

On physical presence, sources said that this was being done as per ECI directions. "Physical presence is mandatory. While their relatives can submit enumeration forms on behalf of the voter during the earlier phase of SIR, voter presence is mandatory during the notice and verification phase," an official said. On notices on age difference being served to only a few siblings in a family, the official said they were looking into the complaints.

Bengaluru-based firm MAC Insights has analysed the 43.81 lakh notices generated in Karnataka. The analysis showed that a little over half the notices (23.28 lakh) were for voters who were unmapped during the last SIR. For instance, the entire family of entrepreneur Nandan Nilekani was issued notices citing this reason.

'Self name mismatch' is the second most common reason, with around 5.2 lakh voters getting notices for this reason.



At BRICS, more options, a win for diplomacy

THERE CAN be two views about BRICS and almost every multilateral forum at a time of churn in global politics. According to the first, such forums are ineffectual pagentry, while the second paints them as merely vehicles for the great powers to build their spheres of hegemonic influence. The New Delhi Declaration 2026 underlines a much-needed third view. It holds that diplomacy, cooperation and exchange of ideas, goods and services need not be beholden to the ideologies and interests of great powers. There is room for different political systems and even states on opposite sides of military conflicts to sit together, to agree, and agree to disagree. The strength of the New Delhi Declaration, then, lies in the spectacular headlines it did not make, and in reasserting the importance of diplomacy as-usual.

As West Asia continues to suffer from prolonged conflicts — Israel and Palestine, Iran and Lebanon and now, Yemen — the consensus between Iran and the UAE that calls for “exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation” is an unambiguous victory for diplomacy. Beyond West Asia, the Declaration focuses on the issues that will outlast the current moment’s rhetoric. Over 130 paragraphs of the 45-page document focused on “unilateral coercive measures” and “unilateral sanctions”, “unilateral blockades” — a comment on, and a push back against, the excesses by Washington under Donald Trump. The message is clear: Supply chains and trade routes of essential commodities, including and especially hydrocarbons, must not be weaponised. For developing countries of the Global South, the energy question is particularly salient. Rather than chasing the chimaera of a BRICS currency, the Declaration does well to focus on linking payment systems among member states. India’s UPI architecture has great potential here. The focus on AI capacity building and digital resilience also carries Delhi’s imprint.

When it was first formed in 2006 and through its early years, BRICS was meant to act as a forum for united action by emerging powers in a unipolar world. Its grand ambitions of “de-dollarisation” and multipolarity have led its detractors to paint it as an attempt to be “anti-West”. In fact, few of the group’s core members, and its expanded roster, hold such a view. China is looking for accommodation with the US, many countries from West Asia are practically allied with Washington; Vladimir Putin shares a personal rapport with Trump; India is looking to firm up a trade deal with America and do more business with Europe. In 2026, an expanded BRICS balances the views and needs of its many members. The New Delhi Declaration emphasises that a plurality of voices must be heard and heeded.

After oil surge, Fed rate hike will shape challenge

ON WEDNESDAY, Brent crude traded above \$100-per-barrel for the first time after May 26, touching \$110 during the week before closing at \$104.6. This week could see the US Federal Reserve raise interest rates when the central bank’s open market committee meets on September 15-16. Unlike oil — where the trigger for the recent price surge has been the Iranian-aligned Houthi militia’s seizure of virtually Yemen’s entire Red Sea coast, threatening navigation through the vital Babel el-Mandeb Strait — the markets have already priced in the Fed’s rate hikes. Ten-year US Treasury bond yields are almost at 5 per cent, the highest since October 2023. The West Asia conflict’s ripple effects are also being felt through US producer price inflation hitting 5.4 per cent year-on-year in August and diesel prices soaring to a record \$6.20 a gallon.

All this matters greatly for India, as an importer of both energy and capital. The higher the prices of oil, and the longer they stay so, the more the impact, in terms of inflation and growth slowdown. The same goes for interest rates. When yields on 10-year government securities are near 3 per cent in Japan, 5 per cent in the US and 5.4 per cent in the UK, why should foreign investors put money in India, where returns aren’t as assured or high, after adjusting for currency depreciation risks? Elevated international energy prices widen India’s current account deficits. These become harder to finance in a rising global interest rates scenario, as capital flows shift to the safe-haven assets of industrialised countries. India has weathered the Iran war-induced energy supply shock relatively well so far. The \$127.2 billion of FCNR(B) deposits mobilised through the RBI’s special dollar-rupee swap facility has also stemmed the run on the rupee.

In the short run, the hope is of some kind of a deal to manage shipping through the effectively shut Hormuz as well as the now-threatened Bab el-Mandeb chokepoints. The important challenge for India, however, lies in boosting its export competitiveness and attracting long-term foreign investor interest. Key to the first is elimination of duties on imported raw materials and components, besides continued investments in roads, railways, inland and coastal waterways, and port infrastructure. The latter entails creating an environment where investors are confident about India not just being a robust long-term growth story, but offering policy predictability and stability. On top of these is the need for fiscal prudence and to guard against government overspending spilling over into higher current account deficits.

India & China are at a Nash equilibrium. Will it hold — that’s the question

ARE WE any the wiser about the course of India-China relations after the Eight Points of Outcomes and Consensus statement on the border issued on August 25 and the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping at the just-concluded BRICS Summit?

What the August statement and the two readouts from India and China after the summit indicate is that, with respect to the border, the two sides are at a Nash equilibrium. For the Economics 101-challenged like me, a Nash equilibrium is an outcome in a non-cooperative game in which “no player’s expected outcome can be improved by changing one’s own strategy” (according to Britannica online). In essence, India and China, at least tacitly, recognise that in any foreseeable future they cannot aspire to and achieve a better position in the border quarrel. They may well spar diplomatically and militarily occasionally, as they have since 2013. But the intermittent war of words and of hardware over control of the high Himalaya can only move the Line of Actual Control slightly.

The border quarrel can only be solved to the maximal satisfaction of India and China by negotiation or by force. India and China have been negotiating a border deal almost without interruption since 1981 — the Secretary/Vice Minister-level talks (1981-88), the

Joint Working Group (1989-2005), and the Special Representative Mechanism (2003-present). Over more than 45 years, they have met once a year on average.

After all those years of talking, the only agreement of substance is the 2005 “Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question”. The most important parameters and guidelines were that a settlement would be reached as a package (nothing is settled until everything on the border is settled). The final agreement would be a “political settlement” that would consider strategic concerns, history, national sentiment, practicality, geography, and the interests of settled populations in the borderlands.

The August 2026 eight-point statement, enjoining the negotiators to seek an early and substantial harvest with respect to the border, does not violate the idea of a package deal. Rather, it suggests that the two sides should focus on success in one area instead of negotiating everything everywhere all at once. Having achieved success in one section, they should then move on to another section of the border. Yet, as per the 2005 agreement, each sectional success would only be finally accepted and ratified when the entire border is settled.

Nothing in the Modi-Xi BRICS readouts alters the basic 2005



KANTI BAJPAI

Two things can disturb the Nash equilibrium (apart from bad defence or internal political collapse): The transition to a successor Dalai Lama, and an India-Pakistan fight that draws China directly in

agreement or the eight-point early harvest statement. The negotiation process has been somewhat nudged by the eight-point statement, but it is hard to imagine that diplomatic bargaining now or in the future can give India or China their maximal objective. For India, the maximal objective is to get back Aksai Chin up to its original claim and to keep everything it has in the other sectors. For China, it is to get Arunachal Pradesh all the way to the southern slopes (which is most of the state) and to keep everything else it has in the other sectors. It is inconceivable that Indian or Chinese negotiators can achieve their maximal objectives.

Nor can they do so by force. India cannot conquer Aksai Chin up to its original claim line, and China cannot conquer Arunachal Pradesh up to the southern slopes. Terrain, climate, logistics, and military defences make any dramatic — and lasting — military gains almost impossible. Short of extremely bad strategy by their commanders or internal political chaos that distracts from deterrence, the status quo on the border is stable.

Two things can disturb the Nash equilibrium (apart from bad defence or internal political collapse): The transition to a successor Dalai Lama, and an India-Pakistan fight that draws China directly in and leads to a two-front war for India.

Eventually, Beijing will appoint its preferred Dalai Lama. The Tibetans will almost certainly choose their own. New Delhi will be caught in the middle. India-China tensions could consequently spiral and China could lash out as it did in 1962 when the instabilities in Tibet were a factor leading to war.

Alternatively, another India-Pakistan fight could spiral. In 2025, New Delhi detected a Chinese helping hand to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor. In a future South Asian confrontation, China might be more ostensively involved. New Delhi or Beijing may then find themselves drawn into a fight that would threaten the status quo.

Beyond the border negotiations and all the other good things that the present détente with China promises — trade, visas, supply chain resilience, river water cooperation — New Delhi should be thinking about the strategic challenges that could disturb the current Nash equilibrium. Can India-China relations be insulated from a Tibet transition and a future India-Pakistan fight? Can the fruits of détente help build sufficient insulation? What more needs to be done with China?

The writer is visiting professor, International Relations, Ashoka University, visiting senior fellow, Centre for Social and Economic Progress, and emeritus professor, Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy, National University of Singapore

The rebuilding of the city must begin, after Satya Niketan



GAUTAM BHATIA

EVERY YEAR, after the monsoon arrives, streets get flooded, and as more rain washes the city and water wends its way into basements and foundations, walls buckle, and buildings collapse. People are trapped inside; some die. At Satya Niketan, 50 Delhi University students were huddled in a makeshift arrangement in an unauthorised building. Seven died, and many others are in serious condition in local hospitals. Could the tragedy have been averted? Given the building’s condition, its age, its unauthorised status, and location in a dense neighbourhood, the answer is a resounding no. As climate change alters weather patterns, causing flash floods and drenching cities with sudden and enormous quantities of rain, it is critical to build physical safeguards that, along with civic governance, can be effectively enforced. For that, several steps are required.

First is the physical mapping of Lal Dora areas, the shadow pockets that evade municipal planning and exist in virtually all big cities. Almost 60 per cent of Delhi’s population currently lives in unauthorised structures — mostly in slums, low-rise makeshift tenements, or high-density four-to-five storey buildings in urbanised villages. While street maps of most illegal colonies exist, there needs to be a building-by-building documentation of the types and sizes of all structures, an assessment of their physical condition, along with an enumeration of the inhabitants. Advanced infra-red and other imaging techniques allow for a reasonably accurate assessment of the buildings’ structural condition.

Gone are the days when buildings were made to last for generations. The life-span of structures built in this century is barely 30-40 years; for those in Satya Niketan — because they follow none of the required safety codes — even less. Even within this short time frame, buildings need to be checked regularly, and if need be, demolished partially or wholly, and replaced.

Most buildings are designed for a specific function — their inappropriate use and heavy load on floors can weaken and damage the structure. A block of flats is designed for domestic use, but in unauthorised colonies many are converted into stores and restaurants, thus increasing the number of occupants and altering the weight on floors. Even makeshift hostels compromise living space to give a more lucrative return to the property owners. Unless building authorities approve a designated building function and allocate minimum floor space per person, no oc-

cupancy permit should be issued.

What then of the density of the colony layout? Builders take no responsibility for the ground they share with neighbouring buildings, but a spatial evaluation of the overall surrounding layout becomes essential to establish safety standards. Is there adequate natural ground around the structure to absorb rainwater? Are there enough wide-mouth drains to move water quickly? Local storm drainage conditions and the open ground available need to be assessed. In most cases, too much building in too small a ground area traps excess water, directing it into basements and foundations, eventually destabilising the structure.

Finally, there is the question of urban governance. Are political parties and their municipal agencies capable of being effective civic authorities? Or should all control of roads, buildings, transport and other infrastructure come under one legal entity, say, the mayor? What indeed is the value of the battery of bye-laws if they can’t be enforced? What is the point of the structural evaluation of buildings if inspectors and site engineers can be easily bribed?

Some years back, a newly constructed apartment in Bengaluru crumbled into a heap of dust just as soon as it was completed. It was approved as a three-storey structure, but the builder decided to increase his profit by adding two more floors illegally, thereby weakening the structural capacity of the columns. The collapse killed 12 people. What was the square-foot gain in income for every life lost? How do you monitor construction activity that could harm, even kill, its occupants?

In the Satya Niketan case, alterations were being carried out in the basement, potentially risking damage to the building. More rooms to house more students, a canteen perhaps? What was happening there was anybody’s guess, but it was enough to destabilise a structure almost half a century old, and bring it crashing down.

By 2030, Delhi will have a population of nearly 40 million, making it one of the world’s densest cities. More students and more migrants from nearby towns will make this their home. Soon civic authorities will need to ask more difficult questions. Can the city continue to accommodate people in every possible leftover space, without services or security? Will builders merely build higher with more unauthorised floor space, and endanger more lives? Or, is it time to seek thoughtful and radical alternatives? Is there space in the municipal mind for new and experimental ideas?

The writer is a Delhi-based architect

The choice is between AI applications and AI frontiers



SUVRAT RAJU

INDIA IS facing a technological crisis. Even as US and Chinese firms have released a parade of increasingly capable AI models this year, India has no competitive frontier model and no realistic prospect of producing one without significant policy shifts. The anticipated impact of AI can be separated into two categories. First, AI can diffuse through the economy by automating some routine jobs. Each industry will require specialised applications built on foundation models. India has an active start-up ecosystem devoted to building such applications, and businesses have rapidly adopted AI tools. However, AI will also have a strategic impact on research, cybersecurity and defence. AI models have been used to solve some of the most important open problems in mathematics. Anthropic’s Mythos model has formidable cybersecurity capabilities; it has not been released publicly, and is available only to selected organisations.

Currently, consumers have access to other frontier models, including Chinese open-weight models. But it is unrealistic to expect this to continue indefinitely. Earlier this year, the US temporarily imposed export restrictions both on Mythos and on a version of Mythos with guardrails called Fable. It is likely to restrict and regulate AI to “achieve global dominance”. US industry leaders and academics have advised India to focus on applications rather than the frontiers — a position supported by sections of the Indian IT industry. But countries that fall behind in frontier AI risk suffering the fate of those that missed the Industrial Revolution: A small business elite might find a niche and prosper, but ordinary people will suffer disempowerment.

India can still catch up to the frontier with a focused effort. The algorithms underlying modern AI models are widely understood. The industry has exploited “scaling laws” that predict how a model’s performance improves with its size and the computing power used for its training. So, while better algorithms improve efficiency, the basic formula for producing frontier models is to scale compute and data. Lack of computing power has bottlenecked sovereign Indian model development. The IndiaAI mission has a pool of 45,000 GPUs. But this is only a fraction of the capacity controlled by a single US frontier lab. The mission allocated 4,096 GPUs to Sarvam AI to train India’s flagship model. This is about 50 times smaller than what is used to train frontier models. No amount of ingenuity can compensate for this resource gap. A number of data centres, with significant computing capacity, are coming up in various states. But these will primarily serve MNCs, and their location in India offers no tangible benefits. Most of the announced capital investment will be directed to electronic equipment, and the employment they create will be limited to a few construction and maintenance jobs. Large data centres have a significant environmental impact. In India, this impact will be borne disproportionately by local communities.

India could use these data centres to alleviate its compute shortage with a “compute tax”: Any data centre established in India would be required to reserve, say, 25 per cent of its computing capacity for a publicly administered national compute pool. This capacity would remain physically within the data centre, but could be allocated by a central scheduler to Indian institutions. MNCs are likely to resist, but their bargaining position is weakened by the growing hostility to these installations elsewhere. Such a tax would not obviate the other data-centre concerns. But together with environmental safeguards and welfare measures, it might open a narrow route to building a frontier model in India.

The writer is professor of Physics, International Centre for Theoretical Sciences, Bengaluru. Views are personal

# A blueprint to create productive jobs, a lesson from Tiruppur



**FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH**  
BY ASHOK GULATI AND  
SULAKSHANA RAO

IN HIS Independence Day address from the Red Fort's ramparts, Prime Minister Narendra Modi placed "manufacturing power" as the first among the seven Saptadharma streams that are to take India towards a Viksit Bharat. He also said this effort would fully harness the potential of India's youth. The pertinent question is, which manufacturing sector can actually deliver jobs at the scale India needs?

Our research at ICRIER points to the textiles and apparel (T&A) sector. But first, why is creating jobs urgent? India's growth story will have little meaning if it fails to create jobs for the masses, and that too in the formal sector. India had 61.6 crore employed persons aged more than 15 years (2025), but agriculture still accounted for 43 per cent of employment, compared with 12.1 per cent in manufacturing (PLFS 2025). Even a 1 per cent point shift in employment from agriculture to manufacturing would involve moving a large number of workers. The NDA had promised to create 2 crore jobs every year, but reality is nowhere near that. The recent student agitations over paper leaks reflected an underlying frustration: Even after acquiring a "three Rs" education, respectable jobs in the formal sector remain scarce. Unemployment among those aged 15-29 was 9.9 per cent, rising to 13.6 per cent in urban areas, while 25 per cent were neither in employment nor in education or training (PLFS 2025). Female labour force participation was 40 per cent, compared with 79.1 per cent for men.

A large share of India's workforce remains in informal employment, without the stability and social protection of formal jobs. The PLFS usual-status measure includes people who worked for a long part of the year

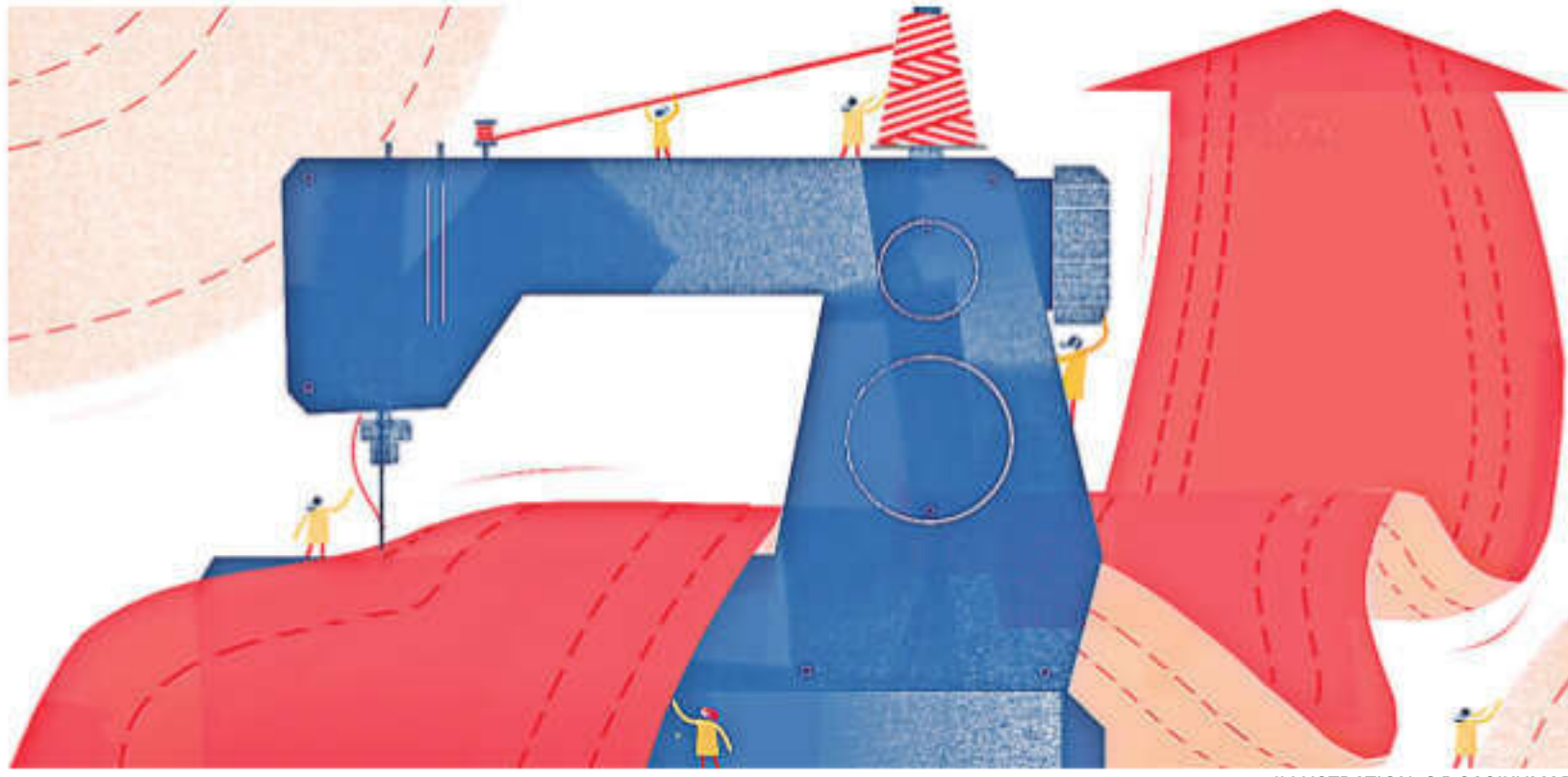


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

as well as those who undertook economic activity for at least 30 days during the year. Being counted as "employed" does not necessarily mean having a regular/formal job. For workers to build economic security and resilience, the shift must therefore be towards regular, formal employment with social-security benefits like Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) and Employees' State Insurance (ESI). This is where the apparel sector matters. It is labour-intensive, employs women in large numbers and can train workers in short periods, about 60 days for specific production roles.

India has set an ambitious target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030 (from \$36 billion today). Of this, \$40 billion is for apparel exports specifically (from \$15.7 billion today). But our interactions with exporters suggest that these targets are not grounded in current realities. They are more likely to be achieved by 2035, not 2030.

One good thing is that India has recently closed the tariff gaps with competitors like Bangladesh and Vietnam in major markets like the EU and the UK. But market access alone does not ensure exports. Take the example of the India-Japan agreement (2011). India's apparel exports to Japan fell from \$229 million in 2013 to \$203 million in 2024.

**The Tiruppur Exporters Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion**

We need the scale and capacity to tap the potential of free trade agreements. The solution is not more factories, but creating a competitive ecosystem around them.

Tiruppur, an organically grown knitwear cluster, is perhaps the most compelling example. Its knitwear exports rose from \$3.3 billion in 2020-21 to \$5.3 billion in 2024-25 (TEA, 2026). The cluster accounts for about 68 per cent of India's knitwear exports and supports the livelihoods of more than a million workers, around 70 per cent of them being women. Within roughly 20 km, yarn, knitting, dyeing, printing, stitching, finishing, packaging and dispatch are woven into one production ecosystem. Nearly 20,000 units operate across different stages, from knitting, dyeing and printing to garmenting and ancillary activities. This is the ecosystem effect where firms specialise,

workers specialise, and thousands of jobs are created around a common market.

So how did Tiruppur do it? Over decades, entrepreneurs, industry associations and government built the institutions and common infrastructure that enabled this ecosystem to grow. The Tiruppur Exporters Association, under the leadership of A Sakthivel, and the

South India Hosiery Manufacturers Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion. The cluster's collective strength was evident in tackling the environmental crisis. After the Madras High Court's 2011 order on units failing to meet zero-liquid-discharge (ZLD) norms, the cluster invested more than Rs 850 crore in common effluent-treatment infrastructure. Tiruppur also shows what it takes to create the next 1 million jobs. The cluster depends heavily on migrant workers from Odisha, Jharkhand, Bihar and elsewhere, making worker housing and retention important challenges. The cluster plans to foray into man-made fibres, technical textiles and high-value sustainable manufacturing to expand both exports and employment.

But Tiruppur alone cannot help achieve the target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030. India needs many more such clusters. Some policy steps in this direction were taken by the government in 2021 in the form of announcing seven PM MITRA parks. But till date, only one such park seems operational (the Warangal one). Others are still in the planning stages. Such a snail's pace in the execution of even good ideas does not inspire confidence that India can achieve its target of \$100 billion exports by 2030. That would also limit the speed at which jobs can be created.

Our humble submission is that the Prime Minister needs to give special attention to this sector if India is to create 20 million meaningful jobs every year. Chip-making, AI and other advanced technologies are important for India's future, but they are for the highly skilled workforce, while the majority of India's labour force is at the bottom end. The T&A sector offers higher employment intensity at relatively low cost. China, Bangladesh, and Vietnam have followed that path, and India needs to learn from them.

The real test of Viksit Bharat is whether it can create enough productive jobs. T&A offers a clear opportunity. But it needs the PM's focus to expedite its execution.

*Gulati is distinguished professor and Rao is senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal*

## Anganwadis shape the future. They are our responsibility



ANNPURNA DEVI

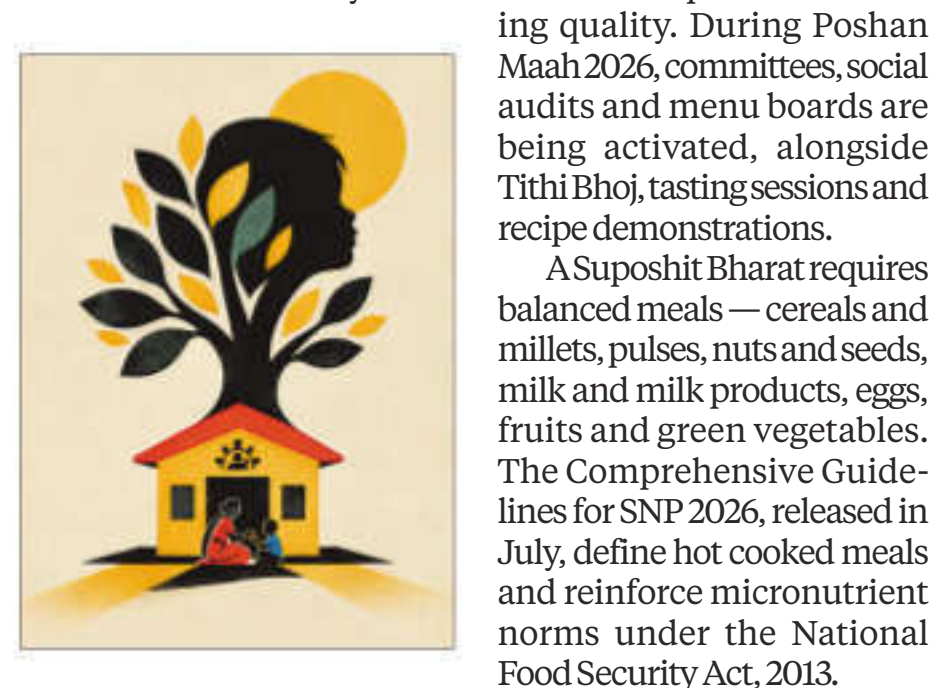
THE BHARAT of 2047 will be built by children who have not yet entered school. Their journey towards a healthy, confident and capable adulthood begins much earlier, most decisively in the first 1,000 days of life. For millions of Indian children and their mothers, that journey is supported by a familiar neighbourhood institution: The anganwadi.

Long before entering the classroom, children are weighed and measured at an anganwadi, get a warm meal and hear rhymes outside the home. Expectant parents also receive counselling. Today, 14 lakh anganwadi centres serve as the first point of contact between the citizens and the state, reaching over 8.9 crore children, women and adolescent girls. The 25.2 lakh anganwadi workers and helpers are drawn from the communities they serve. The anganwadi has always belonged to the neighbourhood.

This institution became the foundation of a national movement when Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched POSHAN Abhiyaan in March 2018. The ninth Rashtriya Poshan Maah began on September 9 with the theme "Hamari Anganwadi, Hamari Jimmedari". The government's commitment to providing quality services is unwavering. But an anganwadi centre truly flourishes when the community embraces it as its own. A Viksit Bharat can be built only through *sabka prayas* (everyone's effort). Nutrition cannot be seen only as a government service.

Community ownership has too often remained an appeal. This year, it becomes an institution. Anganwadi management committees bring parents, panchayat representatives and self-help groups into the centre to ensure every eligible child is reached. Social audits enable communities to review services, verify entitlements and record findings. Accountability becomes verification from within by the families served.

Mothers are at the heart of this process. The menu board of the Supplementary Nutrition Programme (SNP) displays daily entitlements for the hot meals and take-home rations. When a mother knows what her child is entitled to, transparency becomes a habit. The community becomes an informed partner in ensuring quality. During Poshan Maah 2026, committees, social audits and menu boards are being activated, alongside Tithi Bhoj, tasting sessions and recipe demonstrations.



During Poshan Maah 2026, committees, social audits and menu boards are being activated, alongside Tithi Bhoj, tasting sessions and recipe demonstrations.

A Suposhit Bharat requires balanced meals — cereals and millets, pulses, nuts and seeds, milk and milk products, eggs, fruits and green vegetables. The Comprehensive Guidelines for SNP 2026, released in July, define hot cooked meals and reinforce micronutrient norms under the National Food Security Act, 2013.

The second is early learning. What a child eats and learns are deeply connected. Anganwadi workers track 34 developmental milestones in a child's first three years. The Navchetna and Aadharshila curricula carry nutrition and care into school readiness.

The third begins before the child arrives. A mother's nutrition in pregnancy shapes her child's start in life. This Poshan Maah marks 10 years of the Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, reflecting the Prime Minister's conviction that no woman should have to choose between earnings and health. A decade on, 4.65 crore beneficiaries have received Rs 21,511 crore directly into their accounts. Strengthened under Mission Shakti, it provides an additional benefit for a second girl child. The Economic Survey 2025-26 makes clear that such a transfer achieves its full purpose when it travels with counselling that enables informed decisions within the household. Reviewing Rajasthan's Cash Plus model, which paired these transfers with sustained behaviour change communication, it records that the share of women spending the benefit on food rose from 30 per cent to 89 per cent, and that myths surrounding maternal nutrition receded as husbands and families were drawn into the conversation. Partnership grows around anganwadis because a mother's nutrition was never hers to secure alone.

Community ownership cannot mean placing the entire burden of nutrition and early childhood care on the anganwadi worker. It must mean respecting, supporting and strengthening her. This September, I call upon every citizen to visit at least one anganwadi centre in their locality. Speak to the worker, read the menu board and ask how you can support them. Fathers, grandparents, panchayats and self-help groups all have a role. The children being weighed at anganwadis this September will be in their twenties when India completes a century of independence. The health and confidence they carry into that year are being shaped today. When every community takes responsibility for its anganwadi, Bharat takes responsibility for every child's future.

*The writer is Union Minister for Women and Child Development*



CARSTEN SCHNEIDER

THE FOURTH Indo-German Environment Forum, held in Delhi on September 1, focused on climate change and biodiversity conservation. Since the first forum in 2008, global environmental crises have intensified. The political environment for resolving these crises, too, has deteriorated, especially because wars, tariffs and market protectionism have undermined multilateralism. These tensions will have a bearing on India's attempts to simultaneously combat energy poverty and decarbonise its economy.

Yet, there are positive developments. The international community has concluded important agreements, notably the Paris Agreement, the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework and, most recently, the BBNJ Agreement to protect the high seas. India and Germany remain committed to multilateralism, working with partners worldwide to promote stability, reliability, peaceful development and a rules-based international order.

A good example of this is the India-EU trade agreement, concluded in January. Germany, as the EU's strongest economy, is committed to creating new opportunities for growth and jobs for companies in the two countries. Our combined markets serve a population of almost 2 billion people.

India and Germany have been strategic partners for 75 years. In March, we celebrated the anniversary of our diplomatic ties. In January, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chancellor Friedrich Merz met

**In January, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chancellor Friedrich Merz reaffirmed their commitment to the Partnership for Sustainable Green Development**

in Delhi and reaffirmed their commitment to the Partnership for Sustainable Green Development, established in 2022. Cabinet minister-level consultations are planned for 2027 in Berlin.

Both countries are aware of what happens when pressure is placed on the environment. This summer was the hottest on record in Western Europe. India is facing water shortages; large parts of the country faced heatwaves in summer, and then Assam was hit by floods. The devastating flash flood in neighbouring Nepal, which also affected many Indians, has shocked us all. At the same time, India is also proving that climate action and industrial development can go hand in hand through initiatives such as solar parks.

At last year's UN Climate Change Conference in Brazil, we jointly advocated for ambitious climate targets. Climate resilience is becoming an increasingly important goal. The fourth Indo-German Environment Forum was, therefore, fittingly titled "Together for Greater Resilience". With the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry and the Asia-Pacific Committee of German Business (APA), the forum brought together policymakers, business leaders, scientists and representatives of civil society. My counterpart, Bhupender Yadav, and I agreed to pursue technical dialogues on climate adaptation and learn from each other's experiences. We also signed a Dec-

laration of Intent to strengthen cooperation on wetland protection.

More than 2,000 German companies operate in India. Nearly three-quarters of them expect sales to rise this year. More than half plan to increase their investments in 2026. More than 60 per cent manufacture goods in India to meet local demand. One particularly interesting example is the partnership between BHEL and the Dortmund-headquartered Thyssenkrupp Nucera.

The FTA offers significant potential for the development of environmental technologies and a circular economy. The private sector in both countries is already focused on these areas. This also involves the decarbonisation of industry, for example through green steel and low-carbon cement. German and Indian municipalities are working with companies to develop standardised collection and recycling systems, digital traceability chains and tailor-made financing solutions.

I am impressed by India's ambitious targets for solar energy, green hydrogen and growing domestic manufacturing. Germany brings a wide range of experience in grid integration, storage systems and regulation. Through joint initiatives — ranging from the integration of renewable energies to green industrial clusters — we can reduce emissions.

*The writer is federal minister for the environment, climate action, nature conservation and nuclear safety of Germany*

## India, Germany & a green partnership for the future

## To decolonise Hindi is to embrace its many voices



SHAGUN GUPTA

ON HINDI Diwas, we need to ask not merely how Hindi became a modern language, but how we came to imagine what "Hindi" is. Today, Hindi appears to us as a relatively fixed linguistic entity: Standardised Khari Boli written in Devanagari and increasingly associated with a Sanskrit-derived vocabulary. Yet the historical world from which modern Hindi emerged was far more fluid.

In the pre-colonial era, northern India operated with plural linguistic repertoires that shifted naturally by function and social context — whether in the marketplace, the court, the temple, or at home. People did not have a single, exclusive "mother tongue". Literary texts moved across Devanagari, Kaithi, Gurmukhi, and Perso-Arabic scripts.

This porous linguistic landscape was altered by the colonial state's obsession to classify, count, and simplify governance. The initial rupture occurred in the 1830s when the East India Company replaced Persian with vernacular languages in the lower courts, setting up a competition between the sister registers of Hindi and Urdu. The 1900 court resolution in the United Provinces, which permitted Devanagari alongside the Persian script, politicised the issue, turning languages into rigid communal markers.

The decisive partition came with the Pigott Commission of 1912-13. When the policy of maintaining a "common language" collapsed, the colonial government prescribed separate standardised supplementary readers for Hindi and Urdu in 1916, delegitimising rich oral traditions and languages like Bhojpuri, Awadhi, and Braj Bhasha. Early nationalist institutions did not dismantle this British formulation. Organisations like the Nagari Pracharini Sabha and the Hindi Sahitya Sammelan aggressively promoted a highly Sanskritised, Devanagari-based register of Khari Boli as the only "pure" (*shuddh*) national language. Under the editorship of Mahavir Prasad Dwivedi, the journal *Saraswati* became an apparatus for language policing, standardising grammar and purging Arabic and Persian loanwords.

Perhaps the real lesson of Hindi's history is that its greatest strength has never been purity. It has been absorption

Common Hindustani words were substituted with *tatsama* Sanskrit terms. The word for white (*safed*) was replaced by *shvet*, angry (*naraz*) with *krudh*, etc.

To legitimise this artificial creation, these authors performed a double move of historical appropriation and modern exclusion. They expanded the definition of "Hindi" when looking at the past — claiming all medieval poetry, from the Apabhramsa of the *Prithviraj Raso* to the Braj of Surdas and the Awadhi of Tulsidas — even as they restricted its present-day form to one standardised Khari Boli register. The past became plural so that the present could become singular.

This created severe internal hierarchies. Braj Bhasha was dismissed as didactic and erotic. Popular folk forms such as nautanki and oral ballads were devalued. Urdu was alienated. True cultural decolonisation requires us to dismantle these structures of linguistic policing. The linguistic world of North India was built through encounters, borrowings and adaptations. Perhaps the real lesson of Hindi's history is that its greatest strength has never been purity. It has been absorption.

On this Hindi Diwas, we should remember that languages do not grow through walls. The Hindi of the future will be strongest not when it forgets its Persian, Urdu, Braj, and Awadhi inheritances, but when it embraces them as part of its history. To decolonise Hindi is not to make it purer. It is to make it historically whole, embodying the PM's vision of Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat, where unity is not sameness, but the harmonious coexistence of our many voices.

*The writer is a PhD scholar, Department of History, University of Delhi*



Residents leave a building during a Russian drone strike in Odesa on Sunday. REUTERS

# ‘Causing a shortage’: Trump asks Ukraine to halt attacks on Russian diesel hubs

Reuters  
Doonbeg, September 13

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Sunday called on Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy to halt strikes on Russian diesel, saying the attacks are causing a fuel shortage.

Trump was asked by a reporter if he had spoken with Zelenskyy following his recent conversation with Russia's Vladimir Putin. Trump responded by calling on Zelenskyy to halt strikes against Russia.

"Mr. Zelensky has to do one thing. He has to stop knocking out diesel fuel in Russia," Trump told reporters on the sidelines of the Irish Open, which is being played at his Doonbeg golf club.

"Let him go after targets but not diesel fuel, because he's causing a shortage of diesel fuel."

Ukraine's long-range strikes have been targeting Russia's oil and gas industry for months, which Kyiv says both funds and directly fuels Moscow's more than four-year-old invasion of its neighbour.

The Ukrainian drone campaign has caused fuel rationing across Russia, despite the country being a key oil and gas exporter. Other Ukrainian strikes targeted major Russian online retailers, bringing the war ever closer to the public.

Russia has also ramped up its air campaign against Ukraine in recent weeks, using

NO COMMENT BY U.S. MILITARY — WHICH HAS STRUCK IRANIAN VESSELS PREVIOUSLY

# Iranian commercial ship hit near Hormuz, 1 dead

Four persons have been injured in the attack: Report

Associated Press  
Cairo, September 13

AN IRANIAN cargo vessel was struck early Sunday off Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz, Iranian state media said, a day before Tehran plans to brief countries in the region on its contested efforts to manage shipping traffic there.

The attack, which the reports said killed one and wounded four, drew attention back to the strait after threats to shipping in the region intensified last week when Iran-backed Houthi rebels captured an island on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait in the Red Sea.

Iran's state-run IRNA news agency quoted the Qeshm governor as blaming a "terrorist enemy" for Sunday's attack.



Houthi fighters near vehicles abandoned by Saudi-backed forces during a Houthi advance at an undisclosed location in Yemen. AP

There was no immediate comment by the US military, which has struck Iranian-flagged vessels during its blockade of Iranian ports and faces a new threat from Iranian ballistic missiles launched at its warships.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations monitor said a vessel was hit by a projec-

tile while transiting the strait, though it wasn't clear if this was referring to the same attack.

The monitor said a fire had broken out and that local authorities were evacuating those on board. Qeshm Island, about 14 miles from the port city of Bandar Abbas, is key to Iran asserting control over the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump: US could stay in Iran and keep the oil, like Venezuela deal

Doonberg: President Donald Trump suggested on Sunday the US could stay in Iran and "keep the oil", drawing a parallel with a US push to take control of a fifth of Venezuela's vast oil reserves. "We'll ultimately get out (of Iran), unless we decide to stay and keep the oil like Venezuela," Trump said. On a trip to Ireland for meetings and to watch golf, he reiterated that he still expected the Iran war to end this year, possibly just after midterm elections due in the US in November. Speaking at the Irish Open golf championship, Trump added that the price of gasoline would "drop like a rock" once the Iran war ended.

REUTERS

## Russian drone hits passenger train

A RUSSIAN drone hit a passenger train on Ukraine's border with NATO member Poland on Sunday, shortly after former British Prime Minister Boris Johnson and other European diplomats had used the same line. The train, on a route frequently used by foreign delegations returning from Kyiv, was attacked just 2 kilometres from the Polish border, Ukraine's railway operator said. "This wasn't our train, but the one just minutes after us by the border crossing. It was evacuated as the drone approached and no one was hurt," Carl Bildt, former Sweden's PM said on X.

AP

ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones to pierce Ukraine's defenses. Moscow's attacks have targeted Ukraine's power grid ahead of winter in what officials say is meant to demoralize civilians.

Also on Sunday, Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Moscow is open to restarting peace talks in autumn featuring Russia, Ukraine and the U.S.

"We are not ruling out that possibility. We are specifically talking about the foreseeable future. That is, October cannot be ruled out," Peskov told reporters.

INDIA-EU FREE TRADE AGREEMENT PROVIDES MARKET ACCESS FOR 16 CATEGORIES OF STEEL EXPORTS

# India gets 1.64 mt EU steel quota, imports of EU cars may rise 6-fold

Ravi Dutta Mishra  
New Delhi, September 13

AMID TENSIONS over steel exports to the European Union (EU) due to regulations such as the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), India has secured 1.64 million tonnes (mt) of steel export quota, across 16 categories, including specialised items like metallic coated sheets and stainless hot-rolled quarto plates, to the EU under the free trade agreement (FTA), as per draft India-EU deal released by Brussels.

The total country-specific quota falls under two parts, whereby the FTA component comes in at 0.69 mt and the most favoured nation component, available to all partner countries, stands at 0.95 mt. This means that only the FTA component of the quota is assured and India's products will have to compete with other countries in the rest of the categories. India's steel exports to the EU currently stand at 4 mt. The TRQs (Tariff Rate

Quota) follow the EU's Steel Overcapacity Regulation, which came into force on July 1 this year. In trade parlance, TRQ is a tool which limits the trade of quantity of a particular item eligible for lower duty. It aims to ensure protection for the EU's steel industry against the effects of global overcapacity. It sets free-of-duty quotas at 18.3 mt, with a 50% duty for out-of-quota imports and a melt-and-pour regime to enhance transparency.

As per an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER) note, shifting toward higher-value-added steel products will reduce the applicable CBAM tax burden and improve India's competitive position in the EU market. India has received quotas on several value-added categories too. "This structural transition should be supported by industrial policies that integrate Production Linked Incentives with dedicated research and development funding. Targeted financial and technical assistance, in-

## • EU'S STEEL IMPORT RULES

INDIA'S STEEL exports to the EU currently stand at 4 million tonnes

ONLY 17,191 cars were imported by India from the EU in 2025

EU HAS won a first year tariff-rate quota of 100,000 completely built-up internal-combustion and non-plug-in hybrid cars

THE QUOTA rises to 160,000 cars



by the 10th year, but only for cars priced above €15,000

cluding concessional financing, access to clean technology, and investment guarantees, is essential to ease the disproportionate compliance burden on MSMEs," the ICRIER note said.

The draft also showed that EU has won a first-year tariff-rate quota of 100,000 completely built-up internal-combustion and non-plug-in hybrid cars, which is almost six times of the current imports. India imported only 17,191 cars from EU in 2025.

The quota rises to 160,000 cars by the 10th year. But the concession applies only to cars priced above €15,000. For cars priced between €15,000 and €35,000, the in-quota duty falls from 110% to 35% in the first year and down to 10% in the 5th year of the deal coming into effect. To protect Indian car manufacturers, India has given no concession to cars below €15,000. For cars priced above €35,000, tariffs decline from 66% to 30% in the first year

## Gas power generation up 80% amid shortfall

### • Gas power: High demand, evening shortage

| Year (September 1 to September 9) | Generation from gas-based sources (MU) |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| 2026                              | 1,088.64                               |
| 2025                              | 603.70                                 |
| 2024                              | 669.94                                 |
| 2023                              | 1,278.98                               |
| 2022                              | 558.45                                 |
| 2021                              | 1,111.97                               |

SOURCE: NATIONAL POWER PORTAL

Pratyush Deep  
New Delhi, September 13

AMID AN unusual surge in power demand in September, India is increasingly relying on gas-based power to meet evening shortfall as hydropower generation remains constrained and coal-fired plants are operating at near-maximum levels. Electricity generation from gas-based power plants rose 80.3% during September 1-9 from the same period last year, shows an analysis of data from the National Power Portal.

From September 1 to September 9, gas-based power plants generated 1,088.64 million units (MU) of electricity, compared with 603.70 MU during the same period last year and 669.94 MU during the corresponding period in 2024.

Generation during the period was also higher in 2023 and 2021, at 1,278.98 MU and 1,111.97 MU, respectively. The rise in generation is also reflected in purchases by gas-based power generators in the spot market between September 1 and September 10. Natural gas purchases by the power sector jumped to 30,53,300 metric million British thermal units (MMBtu) between September 1 and September 10, from 3,75,000 MMBtu during the same period last year, as per the data from Indian Gas Exchange.

The surge in purchases came even as the average spot gas price rose 139%, from Rs 1,013/MMBtu to Rs 2,420/MMBtu in the same period. While gas accounts for only a small share in the overall generation mix, it plays a key

balancing role in evening peak hours, when solar output falls.

This has become more significant as hydropower generation has declined amid a rainfall deficit. Unlike coal-fired power plants, gas-based plants offer greater operational flexibility and can ramp up or down quickly to meet fluctuations in demand, although their generation costs are higher. A senior government official said the Centre currently relies on at least 4.5-5.5 gigawatts (GW) of gas-based power to meet the evening shortfall. India has a total installed gas-based power generation capacity of 20.1 GW.

Data provided by Grid India show that on September 9, when peak power demand touched 267 GW, the night-time shortfall was around 7.7 GW. On September 10, when peak power demand reached 269 GW, night-time shortfall was at 6.1 GW. As per a senior official, coal-based power plants are operating close to their limits, leaving little room to ramp up generation. "Coal-based power plants are running neck-to-neck and there is no space left to ramp it up. No thermal power plant is left to which we can ask to increase generation. Plant load factor of most imported coal-based plants is around 70% or above. At the same time, hydro-power is going down and likely to go down further as reservoir level is very low in southern and western India," the official said.

Queries sent to Ministry of Power did not elicit any response till press time. FULL REPORT ON

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## Expanding ties

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman met Deputy PM and Minister of Economy and Finance of Republic of Uzbekistan Jamsheed Kuchkarov on Sunday. The two sides discussed bilateral economic and financial cooperation, sharing views on areas of mutual interest. X/@FINMININDIA

to 10% over the same period. The quota is divided among three price bands, with 43,000 units reserved for cars priced above €50,000 from Year 5 onward.

Think tank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said the EU becomes the second major trade partner after the UK to secure automotive tariff concessions from India under an FTA. GTRI said these precedents could prompt other key trade partners, like Japan and South Korea, to seek similar preferential market access and TRQs.

On electric vehicles (EVs), the draft deal said concessions on battery-EVs, plug-in hybrids and cars using other technologies beginning in 5th year apply only to vehicles priced at €20,000 or more. Their Completely Built Unit quota starts at 20,000 cars in the 5th year, rises to 50,000 in the 10th year and reaches 90,000 from 14th year onwards. Electric and other eligible cars priced below €20,000 get no concession. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

## India's semicon sector draws \$1.4 bn funding

Press Trust of India  
New Delhi, September 13

INDIA'S SEMICONDUCTOR sector has attracted \$1.4 billion in all-time equity funding across 281 funded companies, with nearly half of this amount — \$701 million — raised since 2025 alone, according to data from Tracxn. The findings come days ahead of SEMICON India 2026, the country's flagship semiconductor conference and exhibition, which will be held from September 17-19 at Yashobhoomi in Dwarka, New Delhi.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the fifth edition of SEMICON India 2026 on September 17, a mega-event set to bring together global semiconductor industry leaders, government officials, state representatives, and sector experts as India builds on the momentum of its growing semiconductor ecosystem.

# MoSPI Secy: Nominal GDP revised down as informal sector data has improved

NOMINAL GDP estimates under the old 2011-12 series have been revised lower under the new series primarily due to a better picture of the informal sector, Saurabh Garg, Secretary in the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), said in an interview with **Aanchal Magazine** and **Siddharth Upasani**.

Responding to questions raised about the new 2022-23 base-year GDP series — released back in February — that range from downward revisions and use of producer prices for double deflation, Garg told *The Indian Express* that MoSPI had made the best use of data and surveys and, so far, no one has pointed out "something obvious that we must do in the next (GDP series)". Edited excerpts:

**What is the main reason for the reduction in nominal GDP in previous years, not just April-June 2025?**

The primary reason for the downward revision in nominal GDP across all overlapping years (2022-23 to 2024-25 and subsequent quarters) is the transition from proxy-based estimates in the old series to direct, empirical annual surveys for the informal sector in the new series.

In the previous series, because regular surveys for the unorganised sector did not exist, MoSPI calculated Gross Value Added (GVA) for unorganised sector by multiplying estimated workforce counts by the Value Added per Worker derived from decadal surveys. This base year GVA was projected forward for over a decade using proxies like formal corporate growth rates, inter-survey growth rates, or historical tax collections as no regular data was available.

With the availability of annual survey evidence, it has become possible to better capture the distinct growth patterns of the informal sector. This has provided a stronger empirical basis for updating the estimates and improving their alignment with observed economic activity. Therefore, the single largest driver of the revision in GDP numbers is the improved measurement of India's informal services sector.



SAURABH GARG  
SECRETARY, MoSPI

By replacing corporate proxies with actual empirical data from the newly institutionalised Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) and Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), MoSPI transitioned to direct annual measurements of unorganised productivity and workforce size.

**One criticism that has come from former CEA Arvind Subramanian is that the GDP data does not capture the informal economy properly and we are extrapolating the performance of listed companies. Are we not using ASUSE data for quarterly GDP data?**

We are using it. We now have ASUSE on a quarterly basis and PLFS on a monthly basis. So, we are using them; we are not using proxies.

Even in the earlier series, we weren't using only proxies for the informal sector; that was used only between the quinquennial surveys as you had to use something until the next five years. And that was from the previous base years, so that overhang was continuing.

**So, the previous 2011-12 series was overestimating GDP?**

No, that's the point I am trying to make: it's not an overestimation. GDP is an estimation and you make estimates based on the best data available.

When the 2011-12 and 2004-05 series were estimated, certain indicators were used and later changed, leading to better estimates. Now you have even better estimates. Saying it was an overestimation gives the impression there was a systematic bias. That's

alluding a bit much.

**A question raised by Pronab Sen in an interview is the use of producer price data. Is the appropriate data available?**

We had shifted the method of calculation to producers in the 2011-12 series of the WPI itself. That's the old series.

The only differences between WPI (Wholesale Price Index) and PPI (Producer Price Index) are that WPI does not have exports and imports and includes taxes and trade margins to some extent. Apart from that, our WPI was akin to a PPI. But we have made those corrections now. So, the data for the past 10 years has been collected from industry and that change was done way back.

**Another criticism aimed at the GDP data is that this level of growth is not being 'felt' on the ground.**

That, I think we need to recognise, is a larger question. I think the GDP is a very important indicator, no doubt. But there are a lot of other factors, uncertainties, and the global situation which determine how you 'feel'. It's like when someone mentions, 'We feel inflation (rate) should be higher'. So, individually, how you see the prices might be different from when they are aggregated across the country and across different areas. I really wouldn't want to comment on that issue.

**Would you say that this new GDP series is by far the most superior so far?**

Absolutely, without doubt. Every series, at that time, is the best series. There is no doubt (about that) because we are using the best available data.

**Has there been any criticism of the new GDP series that you think is fair?**

Obviously, I think this debate is unnecessary. Yeah, that's a good question. I really can't think (of any) because we have made the best use of data, digital data, and surveys. I don't think anyone has pointed out something obvious that we must do in the next (GDP series).

FULL INTERVIEW ON  
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• ENERGY

# Limits to supply, rising demand: Behind Kerala’s electricity crisis

Shaju Philip  
Thiruvananthapuram, September 13

WITH A few weeks left for the southwest monsoon to withdraw, Kerala is facing an unusual power crisis. The Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) has instituted power cuts lasting between 30 minutes and an hour for managing peak-hour energy demand, including nighttime power cuts. Power demand rises at night, as domestic consumers make up 75% of the state’s power connections. The CPI(M)-led Opposition has blamed the ruling Congress for poor crisis management.

## Low power generation

According to the KSEB, the state’s average daily demand for power in September 2026 was 5,000 megawatts (MW) as against 3,794 MW in September 2025. The state has met only 4,200 MW, resulting in a shortage. Kerala produces only 1,650 MW and gets 1,500 MW from the Central pool. The Union Ministry of Power periodically allocates power generation capacity to states from its pool of unallocated quota in Central Generating Stations (CGS), which are large power-generating stations. Electricity as a subject comes under the Concurrent List of the Constitution, meaning both the Centre and the states have jurisdiction over it. In general, the state generates only 25% of its actual requirement from various sources, including hydel, solar and wind. In comparison, Andhra Pradesh meets 86% of its power demand from its own generation and Tamil Nadu stands at 50%.

## • SOLAR BRIGHT SPOT

Despite low power generation overall, Kerala is a leading state in rooftop solar power generation. Under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, Kerala has 2.96 lakh installations covering 3 lakh households. But this does not help meet the nighttime demand, given a lack of options to store it.

Notably, Kerala is a leading state in rooftop solar power generation. Its solar production hit 2,508 MW by the end of May, with a vast majority being rooftop panels. Under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, Kerala has 2.96 lakh installations covering 3,03,531 households. But solar power does not help Kerala meet the nighttime demand, given a lack of options to store it. The KSEB has lined up a slew of Battery Energy

Storage Systems (BESS) that are yet to become operational.

## Poor monsoon

The El Niño effect, or the abnormal warming of surface waters in the equatorial Pacific Ocean that can suppress the Indian monsoon, has been witnessed this year. The southwest monsoon has been weak during the June-September period, with Kerala recording a 26% deficit in seasonal rainfall till September 11. Official data shows that the water storage in all KSEB reservoirs was only at 63.75% of the maximum storage level as of September 10. This has forced the KSEB to throttle down hydropower generation, considering the withdrawal of the monsoon and higher temperatures in the next few weeks.

The poor monsoon and sudden temperature spike since late August have contributed to an increase in power demand, mainly from domestic consumers. The state disaster management authority has put Kerala on alert due to an unusual rise in temperature, with a departure of up to 4 degrees Celsius from normal. Rising night temperatures are further driving long-duration AC usage. The KSEB has also found that the nighttime demand is rising owing to the charging of electric vehicles. Kerala is ready to buy power at higher rates from power exchanges elsewhere, but it faces another grim prospect. Nationally, too, power generation has been low due to factors such as a poor monsoon and low coal stock at power plants. India is also witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, with peak power demand nearing the level recorded during peak summer.

• POLICY

# Outstation students pouring in, why Delhi University doesn’t have enough hostels

Rishika Singh  
New Delhi, September 13

THE COLLAPSE of a Paying Guest (PG) accommodation in South Delhi’s Satya Niketan recently, which led to the deaths of at least seven people, including students, has spotlighted the lack of hostels in Delhi University (DU) colleges. Over a PIL on auditing such buildings, the Delhi High Court has flagged “the absolutely inadequate number of hostels available to students”. Satya Niketan is one of the many localities that have emerged as hubs of private student housing over the decades, partly because of their proximity to DU colleges. But students often end up crammed in windowless rooms of badly constructed buildings, with poor quality of food and water.

The gap

The Delhi University Act of 1922 led to the establishment of one of India’s premier central universities. Section 33 states that, “Every student of the University (other than a student who pursues a course of study by correspondence) shall reside in a College a

Hall, or under such conditions as may be prescribed by the Ordinances.” “Hall” refers to student residence that the university provided, maintained or recognised. Over a century later, however, the university has significantly expanded in scale. DU’s Annual Report for 2024-25 notes that from three colleges and 750 students in North Campus, it spans 90 colleges, 20 standalone hostels and over 6 lakh students (those enrolled in person and distance learning) today. Around 2.5 lakh come under the conventional mode, and more than half of the students come from regions other than Delhi, the report said. Not all 90 colleges offer residence, and the university does not offer consolidated data on the total number of hostel seats. Around 2015, it was reported that against an estimated 1.8 lakh students enrolled with DU at the time, only about 9,000 seats were available in its hostels for both undergraduate and postgraduate students. Many colleges coming under the South Campus specially, which was established in 1973 to cater to growing demand, lack hostels, or have hostels that can cater to less

than 10% of the total student population.

The roadblocks

The demand for increasing the number of hostel seats has been raised repeatedly over the years. Haritama Chopra, principal at South Campus’s Maitreyi College, told *The Indian Express* that the share of outstation students has grown with deepening access to technology and the university’s admissions process shifting online about a decade ago. V S Negi, the president of the Delhi University Teachers’ Association (DUTA), said that the organisation has raised the issue in the past, but colleges have cited constraints. “Very little has been seriously done to provide hostel facilities to all students,” Negi told *The Indian Express*. Those within the administration, however, say that even with expansions, need for external accommodation will remain due to the sheer number of outstation students. Bijayalaxmi Nanda, principal of North Campus’s Miranda House, said their limitations range from space constraints to specific regulations that govern construction and expansion: “Every college has a par-

Satya Niketan, where the PG accommodation collapsed. PRAVEEN KHANNA

tical capacity, based on its landholding size. Then say a building like ours, established in 1948; that is a heritage building in a sense.”

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

# The problem in OpenAI’s Navier-Stokes ‘solution’



NAMEERA ANJUM

OPENAI’S CLAIM that its artificial intelligence (AI) agents have generated a solution to the Navier-Stokes Millennium Prize Problem has posed a new question for mathematical research: What happens when researchers’ work is fed into AI systems, and “de-identified” data from those interactions is later used to improve the models? The ChatGPT maker said its researchers and AI agents did not access specific user data to solve the problem. But in a blog post on September 8, the company also said it could not rule out the possibility that de-identified data from researchers’ use of its products had helped improve its models.

De-identified data refers to information from which personal identifiers — as to who generated the data — have been removed. But that does not necessarily mean the underlying information, ideas or content have not been used by a model.

The blog post has drawn scrutiny from mathematicians, particularly because New York University professor Tristan Buckmaster and Anthropic researcher Levent Alpöge had been working on related Navier-Stokes research using AI tools, including OpenAI’s Codex.

“De-identified use of a researcher’s conversations blurs the line between assisting someone’s thinking and drawing on it without their knowledge,” Vijay Keswani, assistant professor of computer science at IIT Delhi, told *The Indian Express*.

For Keswani, the issue goes beyond data privacy. It raises questions of “epistemic ownership”: whether AI companies can draw on ideas generated by researchers using their tools without clear acknowledgment or consent.

The controversy comes as AI systems are increasingly being used not just to assist mathematicians but to generate proofs and explore problems that have resisted human researchers for decades.

## De-identification

The exact process OpenAI uses for de-identification in this context is not publicly

## • A MILLION-DOLLAR PROBLEM

The Navier-Stokes Millennium Prize Problem is one of the seven mathematical problems identified by the Clay Mathematics Institute, carrying a million-dollar bounty for whoever cracks it

THE NAVIER-STOKES equations — which build on 19th-century work by Claude-Louis Navier and George Gabriel Stokes — describe how fluids move, taking into account factors such as pressure, velocity, and viscosity. They are used to model everything from water flowing around a boat and air moving around an aircraft to blood moving through the human body.

clear. This has become particularly sensitive in mathematics, because researchers increasingly use AI systems to discuss unfinished ideas, test approaches and work through problems before publishing them.

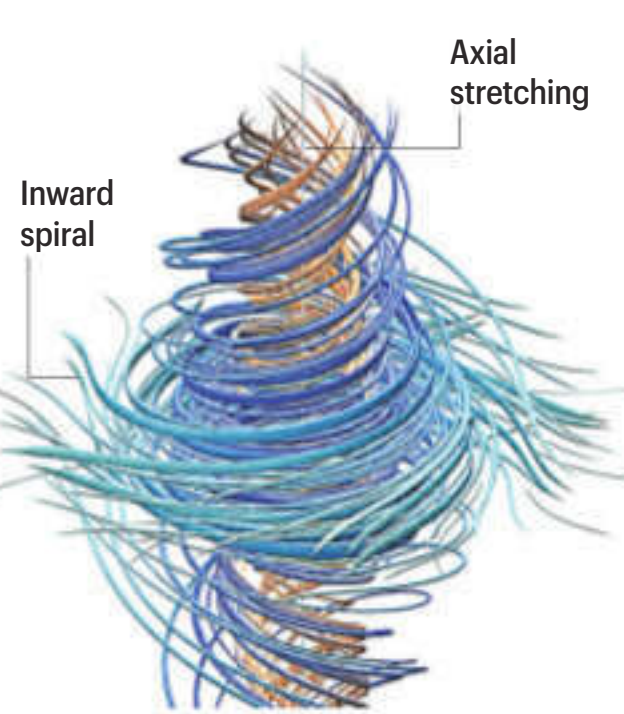
OpenAI has said no specific user data was accessed to solve the Navier-Stokes problem. But that is a narrower claim than ruling out the possibility that de-identified data from users’ interactions may have contributed to training or improving its models.

Keswani said the concern is amplified by the imbalance between individual researchers and AI companies. “Is it fair for a company to have visibility into researchers’ ideas and be able to leverage that visibility, combined with vast computing resources available only to them, to scoop the researchers whose thinking informed the result?” he said. He also pointed to a distinction between what may be permitted under a service’s terms and what researchers may reasonably understand as informed consent: “De-identified” use of a researcher’s conversations may be permitted under terms of service, but that is different from the researcher knowingly consenting to their ideas being used in a competing research effort.

mitted under a service’s terms and what researchers may reasonably understand as informed consent: “De-identified” use of a researcher’s conversations may be permitted under terms of service, but that is different from the researcher knowingly consenting to their ideas being used in a competing research effort.

## OpenAI’s approach

In its blog post, OpenAI said 10,000 currently running AI agents — systems



A vortex demonstrating fluid flow under the Navier-Stokes equations. OPENAI

## Blurred lines

De-identified data refers to information from which personal identifiers — as to who generated the data — have been removed.

But that does not necessarily mean the underlying information, ideas or content have not been used by an AI model.

THE PROBLEM is whether, in three dimensions, a fluid that starts out behaving smoothly can always continue to do so — or whether its behaviour can become infinitely intense in a finite amount of time. In simple terms: if you start with a fluid whose motion is well-behaved, can the equations ever produce a point where the fluid’s velocity becomes infinitely large?

THIS POSSIBILITY is called a singularity or ‘blow-up’. The equations allow different scales and forces within a fluid to interact in complicated ways, and understanding whether those effects can lead to a blow-up is at the heart of the problem.

that carry out tasks autonomously — cracked the problem in about 88 hours. The result was then formalised in Lean, a proof assistant used for checking mathematical arguments.

OpenAI said its paper constructs a mathematical fluid that starts from rest and, under a specially constructed smooth external force, develops a point at which the velocity grows without bound in finite time, while its overall energy remains bounded. The result has not yet been independently verified or accepted by the mathematics community. Clay Mathematics Institute continues to list Navier-Stokes among the unsolved Millennium Prize Problems, while the Poincaré Conjecture remains the only one of the seven to have been resolved.

Siddhartha Gadgil, professor of mathematics at IISc Bangalore, told *The Indian Express* that the use of formal verification could be significant as AI-generated mathematics becomes more common. “Lean provided hope for a superhuman level of correctness,” he said. “This can be much better than human evaluation for checking correctness,” although he cautioned that it is not foolproof.

A formally verified proof could also offer something beyond checking whether an argument follows logically from its formal assumptions. “Once we have a proof object in Lean — we can simplify it, view it in many ways, and try to extract insights,” he said.

But formal verification does not answer the question of how an AI model arrived at the result in the first place.

The question of whether an AI system can make a mathematical discovery is not entirely new. In May, one of OpenAI’s internal models successfully tackled the famous planar unit distance problem.

Notably, the previous breakthrough reflected AI’s reasoning and creation capabilities, as the “problem had no answer to retrieve. The model produced a new construction that humans had not found in 80 years of trying,” Sayan Ranu, professor of computer science at IIT Delhi, told *The Indian Express*.

## Recognition and rewards

If an AI system produces a proof that humans had not previously found, mathematicians may have to grapple with a question that traditional math research has largely avoided: is producing a correct proof enough to count as mathematical discovery if the machine’s route to that result is difficult for humans to understand?

“We lack reliable tools to trace how a model arrived at a given output,” Keswani said. That makes it difficult to determine whether a result is a near-retrieval of something already present in a model’s training data, a recombination of existing ideas, or genuinely new reasoning.

According to Keswani, current AI systems have not demonstrated complete autonomy in scientific research, because humans continue to frame the problem, define the objective and determine what constitutes a successful result.

For Gadgil, the question also extends to how mathematics recognises and rewards discoveries. “The traditional systems of credit and evaluation, including the Millennium Prize Problems, will face many problems in the age of AI,” he said.

On Russian mathematician Grigori Perelman’s solution to the Poincaré Conjecture, Gadgil said “it was years before other mathematicians worked out the details and accepted this as correct”.

On Friday, 25 Fields Medal winners issued an open declaration titled “A Severe Misalignment of AI in Mathematics”, warning that the AI industry’s push to use mathematical problem-solving as a benchmark risks undermining the discipline’s focus on conceptual understanding and insight.

Meanwhile, OpenAI declined to claim the Millennium Prize for its result, saying that the aim behind releasing it was to report on the progress of its AI models.

• ECONOMY

# Copper prices up: Fear of Trump tariffs amid US-China tensions

Pratyush Deep  
New Delhi, September 13

COPPER PRICES have surged in recent months to hit a record high of \$14,767.5 per tonne on September 9. Three-month copper futures, which are contracts for future purchase, on the London Metal Exchange (LME) remained above the \$14,000-per-tonne mark for most of August before climbing in September.

## Why copper price rise matters

The red metal is essential to the modern economy, with uses ranging from housing and manufacturing to power grids, clean energy, artificial intelligence and defence. Thus, its price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust economic growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown. However, the current rally appears to have a different story.

According to industry insiders, the surge is less about expectations of stronger global economic growth and more about concerns over potential tariffs by the United States, which could come into effect from January 2027.

## US-led factors

While US President Donald Trump imposed a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports in August last year, refined copper has so far been exempted. However, there is a proposal to impose a 15% tariff on refined copper imports from January, to be increased to 30% in 2028. “In anticipation of US tariffs, people are selling materials from LME warehouses to warehouses of US COMEX (Commodity Exchange). As a result, there has been a shortage of copper stocks that can be traded on the LME. That is why the futures prices have gone up,” an industry executive told *The Indian Express*. This has resulted in a huge buildup of

## Against trend

Copper price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown. However, the latest rise comes despite prospects of steady global economic growth clouded by trade tensions, the West Asia conflict, and uncertainty.

inventories in the US, two industry sources told *The Indian Express*. “Inventory at LME is currently at 2,65,000 tonnes, and inventory at Shanghai Futures Exchange (SHFE) is at around 63,000 tonnes. However, the inventory of US’ COMEX is at around 7,00,000 tonnes,” an industry source told *The Indian Express*.

Sumit Jhunjhunwala, Vice President & Sector Head, Corporate Sector Ratings, ICRA Ltd, also said that copper prices have remained elevated mainly due to constrained mine supply and the ongoing geographical rebalancing of inventories. “Any major delay or lower-than-expected US tariff could reverse these inventory flows, potentially releasing accumulated stocks into global markets and exerting downward pressure on copper prices,” Jhunjhunwala said.

## Copper in US-China trade war

Last year, too, Trump’s imposition of a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports prompted US buyers to

stockpile the metal ahead of its implementation on August 1, heavily contributing to the surge in copper prices.

The move followed a report submitted by the US Secretary of Commerce, which claimed that copper imports threatened to impair US national security.

In 2025, the US imported \$16.2 billion worth of copper products. China accounted for 20% of these imports, followed by Mexico at 17%, the European Union at 14%, Canada at 10% and Vietnam at 8%, as per the US Congressional Research Service.

In April that year, Trump announced a 50% tariff on the full value of semi-finished copper products and a 25% tariff on the full value of copper-intensive derivative products. The latter rate was reduced to 10% where at least 95% of the copper, steel and aluminium used in the product was sourced from the US. These tariff measures are part of broader trade tensions between the US and China, with China being the world’s largest consumer of copper.



## MAXIMS OF METABOLISM

DR ANOOP MISRA

EXECUTIVE CHAIRMAN,  
FORTIS C-DOC, NEW DELHI

## Should we be giving weight-loss drugs to children?

Consider long-term safety, nutrition and affordability, change family habits

A PHASE III TRIAL by Danish drugmaker Novo Nordisk has shown that about four in 10 children with obesity, who received once-weekly semaglutide, were no longer classified as having obesity after 68 weeks. The STEP Young trial, which involved children aged six to under 12 years, found that 40.4 per cent of children treated with semaglutide moved below the obesity threshold, compared with none in the placebo group. The trial met its primary endpoint, showing a greater reduction in body mass index (BMI) among children receiving semaglutide. The drug was studied alongside lifestyle modification. Both the semaglutide and placebo groups followed a reduced-calorie diet and increased physical activity throughout the 68-week trial. More than 85 per cent of the children enrolled had class II or class III severe obesity at the start of the study.

So, how significant is this result? In India, where childhood obesity is an escalating problem, a 40.4 per cent reduction to below the obesity threshold is clinically meaningful. Many children with severe obesity are already on a trajectory toward early-onset Type 2 diabetes, metabolic dysfunction-associated steatotic liver disease (MASLD), hypertension, polycystic ovarian syndrome (PCOS) and premature cardiovascular disease. Achieving substantial weight reduction within roughly a year, particularly in children with severe obesity, may alter their long-term metabolic trajectory and in fact, change their life completely. However, sustained benefits will depend on maintaining healthy behaviours and appropriate long-term management.

Even in the trial, both the semaglutide and placebo groups received a reduced-calorie diet and increased physical activity. Because both groups received lifestyle intervention, the difference between the groups largely reflects the additional effect of semaglutide. The substantial difference in weight reduction, therefore, demonstrates that semaglutide can provide an important incremental benefit when added to lifestyle measures. However, lifestyle modification remains fundamental. Children need to develop sustainable eating, activity, sleep and behavioural habits; medication should complement these changes, not replace them.



**Watch eating, sleep, activity; medication is complementary, not a replacement**

The bigger question is whether pharmacological treatment should be begun at such a young age? In carefully selected children with severe or clinically significant obesity, pharmacological treatment may help interrupt the progression toward adolescent type 2 diabetes, hypertension, fatty liver and other obesity-related complications. It may also improve physical functioning and reduce some of the psychological burden associated with severe obesity, including weight-based bullying and social stigma which may result in mental stress and depression.

The key concern about pharmacological treatment in primary school-aged children raises legitimate questions about long-term safety, effects on nutrition and development, duration of treatment, affordability and access. There is also a risk of medicalising obesity without adequately addressing the family and environmental factors that drive it. In India, the high cost and limited availability of these therapies mean that they are currently inaccessible to the vast majority of families. Cost consideration is particularly important given the possibility of long term therapy.

The available clinical trial data are reassuring, with no major adverse signals regarding growth or pubertal development over the relatively short period studied (68 weeks). However, these data cannot answer questions about decades of exposure, and long-term surveillance remains essential. Nutrition deserves particular attention in India because obesity can coexist with micronutrient deficiencies — the so-called double burden of malnutrition. Semaglutide markedly reduces appetite and food intake, so adequate intake of protein, micronutrients and other essential nutrients must be ensured during periods of rapid growth, when linear growth and acquisition of peak bone mass are especially important. Such attention to nutrition must continue during treatment and when treatment is being withdrawn.

Management should, therefore, be comprehensive: appropriate assessment of glucose metabolism, lipids and liver health; improvement in physical activity and fitness; adequate protein and micronutrient intake; reduction in excessive screen time and ultra-processed foods; and attention to mental health. Most importantly, parents need to modify household eating and activity patterns alongside the child.

Anonna Dutt

FOR NEARLY a year, 49-year-old Kerala lawyer Majida MA has started her mornings with a phone call from a friend. The call is a reminder to take the medicine that, in her words, is keeping her breast cancer at bay. After breakfast, Majida takes three tablets of the targeted therapy drug ribociclib, sold as Kryxana in India and Kisqali globally, and begins work from home. She has not been able to work from the office next to her house because it is not air-conditioned. The drug causes itching and mood swings, she says, making it difficult for her to work in the heat. “Other than that, and sometimes hair fall, body ache and some discolouration of the skin, I actually do not feel like a cancer patient at all,” she says.

The tablets, however, come with a cost that is increasingly difficult to ignore. Each strip of 21 pills costs about Rs 25,000. Majida needs three strips a month, taking her monthly drug bill to around Rs 75,000–80,000 — a large part of her income as a practising lawyer. “How can I manage to spend Rs 80,000 every month just for the medicine?” she asks. “There are other expenses such as hospitalisation for chemotherapy, tests and doctor consultations. Then there are the fees for my two children — one is in the first year of college and the other in sixth standard.” Her husband and both their parents also live with the family. Her elderly parents and in-laws have their own age-related illnesses and medication expenses. “All of this adds up,” she says.

Initially, her health insurance covered the cost of the medicine. In recent months, however, her claims have been denied, leaving her to pay out of pocket. The fear is not simply financial. Majida knows what can happen when the cost of treatment becomes impossible to sustain. A relative with the same type of cancer had been prescribed the same medicine and took it for nearly a year before stopping because of the financial burden. She died later. “I do not want to stop taking this medicine,” Majida says, who has now become a petitioner in a case before the Kerala High Court seeking greater access to expensive cancer medicines.

### A legal battle over access

The case was originally filed in 2022 by a retired bank employee, who has since died. The Kerala High Court subsequently converted it into a Public Interest Litigation (PIL). Earlier this year, the Supreme Court registered a suo motu petition and directed the High Court to resolve the matter expeditiously. At the heart of the case is a question that is both legal and medical: How can patients gain access to an effective cancer treatment when the patented drug is prohibitively expensive? The petition seeks the use of provisions under the Patents Act that could allow the government to use the patented medicine or facilitate a compulsory licence for a generic manufacturer in circumstances such as a national emergency.

Dr Arathi PM, faculty at the School of Indian Legal Thought at Mahatma Gandhi University, became interested in the case after her friend Majida joined it. “While patents are necessary to motivate companies to develop newer therapies, if you look at the turnover of companies holding the patent for this molecule, they are making huge profits while patients are unable to access it,” she says.

The problem, she says, is not necessarily that a drug does not exist but that its price can determine who gets the opportunity to receive it. The contrast became particularly stark when Arathi posted about the case online. An acquaintance in Oman contacted her to say she had the same type of cancer and was able to access the medicine through her husband’s government coverage.



GETTYIMAGES

## This cancer drug costs Rs 80,000 per month

### Why a survivor fears she may have to give it up

For Kerala lawyer Majida MA, three tablets every morning have become a lifeline. She has now joined a legal battle seeking better access to a breast cancer drug that eats into her income



FIGHTING THE GOOD FIGHT: Kerala lawyer Majida MA

“But there were four other women undergoing treatment for the same type of cancer with her who were never even prescribed the medicine by the doctors because they knew they would not be able to afford it,” Arathi says. That raises another question: what happens when affordability begins to influence treatment choices?

### The medical question

The current debate before the court includes whether patients such as Majida could instead be treated with palbociclib, another drug in the same class for which cheaper generic versions are available. Both ribociclib and palbociclib are CDK4/6 inhibitors. They block proteins called cyclin-dependent kinases 4 and 6, which play an important role in the growth and division of cancer cells. But being in the same drug class does not automatically make two medicines interchangeable.

While the court asked National Cancer Institute, Jhajjar, and Chittaranjan National Cancer Institute, Kolkata to respond on whether the medicines can be used inter-



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changeably, other doctors have weighed in on possibilities. Dr R Ravi Kannan, director of Cachar Cancer Hospital and Research Centre in Assam, says the evidence for the two drugs differs depending on the setting in which they are used.

Palbociclib has shown benefit in metastatic breast cancer, he says, but clinical trials have not demonstrated the same benefit when it has been used as supportive treatment after surgery for early-stage breast cancer. Ribociclib, along with another CDK4/6 inhibitor, abemaciclib, has shown gains in disease-free survival in selected patients with early-stage disease.

“Early-stage breast cancer is treated with curative intent,” Dr Kannan says. “The goal is to eliminate any microscopic disease that could later metastasise. Effective adjuvant therapy or treatment given after surgery to reduce the risk of the cancer returning can drastically improve long-term survival,” he adds. Dr Abhishek Shankar, an oncologist at the All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, stresses that the choice of treatment has to be made in the context of the individual patient. “Ribociclib and palbociclib are both in the same CDK4/6 inhibitor group but they should not be considered automatically interchangeable,” he says. “Both the drugs have different clinical evidence, approved indications, treatment duration and outcome data, particularly between early and metastatic disease.” The decision, he says, should be based on the disease setting, clinical evidence, toxicity, availability and affordability.

The distinction matters because breast cancer is not one disease with one treatment. It is the most common cancer among women in India, with 2.37 lakh cases and more than 96,000 deaths reported in Globocan 2024 data. Majida’s cancer — hormone receptor-positive (HR-positive) and HER2-negative — is the most common biological subtype. This is a common type in which the cancer cells are fuelled by hormones such as oestrogen or progesterone but do not have

unusually high levels of the HER2 protein, which can make the cancer aggressive.

But, as Shankar points out, that does not mean every patient with HR-positive, HER2-negative disease requires a CDK4/6 inhibitor. “HR-positive, HER2-negative disease represents a large proportion, roughly 70 per cent, of breast cancers, but this does not mean all these patients require a CDK4/6 inhibitor,” he says. “The drugs are used in selected patients, particularly those with advanced/metastatic disease and, for certain cases, carefully defined high-risk early breast cancer.” Even the National Cancer Institute, Jhajjar, in its affidavit concluded: “Both agents are acceptable preferred agents endorsed by multiple cancer societies across the world.” But, it added the caveat that this conclusion applied only to metastatic, advanced stage breast cancer and not early stage breast cancer.

### Affordability vs treatment

For patients who do need these medicines, the availability of cheaper alternatives can make a significant difference. “Access has improved substantially, particularly after the availability of generic palbociclib, which can be obtained at a much lower price than the innovative product,” Dr Shankar says. But even a lower price can remain unaffordable when treatment continues for months or years. “Long-term monthly treatment remains a significant financial burden for many Indian families, especially when treatment is predominantly out of pocket,” he adds.

That is the reality Majida is confronting. She says there is little scope for her to simply work more to meet the rising costs. She is already trying to maintain her legal practice while undergoing cancer treatment and managing side effects. For now, she continues taking the three tablets every morning. “I don’t want to give up,” she says. The question, therefore, is larger than one patient’s monthly bill. It is about drugs that exist versus privilege that can claim them for use.

## WHY ARE SOME CANCER MEDICINES SO EXPENSIVE?

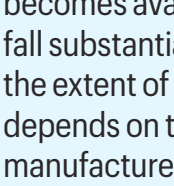
The price of a cancer therapy is shaped by far more than the cost of making a tablet. Several factors can influence what patients eventually pay



**RESEARCH & DEVELOPMENT**  
Developing a new cancer drug can take years of laboratory research, clinical trials and regulatory review. Pharmaceutical companies seek to recover these costs from medicines that reach the market.



**TARGETED MEDICINES**  
Many newer cancer drugs are designed to act on specific biological pathways involved in cancer. These medicines can be considerably more expensive than older, widely used drugs.



**INSURANCE MATTERS**  
The amount a patient actually pays depends not only on the listed price but also on health insurance coverage, reimbursement rules and whether the medicine is included in a particular policy.



**THE RESULT FOR PATIENTS**  
Cancer treatment is rarely limited to the cost of one medicine. Hospitalisation, diagnostic tests, consultations, surgery, chemotherapy, radiation and supportive medicines can all add to the financial burden. This is why access to cancer treatment is increasingly discussed not only as a medical issue, but also as a question of affordability and financial protection.

### WHAT DOES ‘TARGETED CANCER THERAPY’ MEAN?

● Unlike traditional chemotherapy, which can affect both cancerous and healthy fast-growing cells, targeted cancer therapies are designed to interfere with specific molecules or biological pathways that help cancer cells grow, survive.

● Think of cancer cells as having certain molecular “switches” that help them

multiply. Targeted medicines aim to identify and block some of these switches. Because they act on particular features of cancer cells, they can sometimes affect healthy cells less broadly than conventional chemotherapy. However, they are not free of side effects, and their benefits vary depending on the type and biology of the cancer.

## WHY ASHWINI BHIDE

Ashwini Bhide is the first woman municipal commissioner in the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) 133-year old history. Bhide has spearheaded Mumbai's most ambitious infrastructure projects including the Mumbai metro project and the coastal road project, gaining her the moniker of Mumbai's infra woman. Her appointment also comes at a time when the elected representatives return to Mumbai after a hiatus of four years with the Bharatiya Janata Party and Shiv Sena-led the Mahayuti regime being at the centre of BMC's affairs

**Nayonika Bose: Mumbai's road network is barely comparable with other cities in the country. Why do you think we have not been able to develop Mumbai's roads?**

It is not enough that we have just have a budget. Mumbai is a linear city. It is peninsular in nature and on three sides, there is the ocean, so we cannot expand. We have 448 sq km of suburb, with large chunks of the forest and the national park in it along the Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ). So, the actual area available for development and road network is less. If you compare it to Delhi, which has a road network of more than 28,000 km, Mumbai has only 2,050 km. We have tried to bridge this by exploring underground corridors such as the Goregaon Mulund Link Road (GMLR) and the coastal ring road which will connect Marine Drive and Virar. As for the issue of road quality, we are concretising approximately 700 km. The road quality also gets affected due to frequent trenching. Unlike other cities, all utility corridors run beneath the road surface. We have roughly 27 to 30 utilities and they need to be constantly repaired or augmented for which trenching is critical. Currently, we are developing a trenching policy which will be designed to incentivise the use of dedicated ducts. The infrastructure deficit will have to be made up by public transport. For that, the entire metro network will need to be completed, which is expected in two-three years.

**Pratip Acharya: The fleet of BEST buses is shrinking. Are we over investing in metros and do we need to focus more on other modes of transport for the last-mile connectivity?**

We cannot say that there is an over investment in the metro as that is absolutely required. But I can say that there is an under investment in buses or other last-mile transport. However, the problem is the size of the fleet. In Mumbai, the bus fleet size is roughly 2,600-2,800 while the city needs 7000 to 10,000 buses. For a city where maximum trips are made on foot, our pedestrian infrastructure remains extremely poor. We are addressing this with our pedestrian-first policy, where we are prioritising by clearing encroachments near stations. Last-mile connectivity is not a simple, linear thing but a mix of multiple things. Action needs to be taken by different authorities, even people have to change certain habits.

**Pratip Acharya: Despite BMC's mammoth budget, Mumbai always ranks low on the national Swachh Survekshan list. How is BMC working to improve cleanliness?**

We collect 7,000 metric tonnes of solid waste and 8,000 metric tonnes of construction debris daily. The challenge lies in transporting it to the processing grounds and ensuring that nothing is left on the road or on open spaces. Our biggest challenge is that 40 per cent of our population is living in slums where waste collection is difficult. Since these are not organised households, they do not put their dustbins outside even if we go there daily at 7 am. We have identified garbage vulnerable points (GVPs). There are roughly 186 GVPs in the city alongside 200 garbage hotspots. We are attempting to eliminate them by deploying NGOs and using digital applications. But, as citizens, we also need some self-discipline and should not litter.

**Shubhangi Khapre: The 2005 floods in Mumbai highlighted the absence of adequate storm water drainage. How challenging are mitigation efforts given different climatic challenges?**

We are far better equipped today than we were in 2005. However, the challenge of climate change, erratic and extreme weather events still looms. Currently, our drainage has the capacity to handle 55 mm rainfall in an hour, which is more than adequate in normal situations. However, when rainfall crosses more than 100 mm to 300 mm in low-lying areas within a short timespan, then this network may fall short. There are temporary storage solutions too, such as underground tanks, identification of areas with water-logging and restricting people's movement there. Additionally, we have submitted an urban flood mitigation plan to the Central government which will be funded under the National Disaster Relief Fund. The central part is early warning for which we have been leveraging help from IIT Bombay which gives us three day's localised predictions daily. Accordingly, we ensure that the pumps are working, traffic police are informed and rerouting is done.

**Mohamed Thaver: There is also anxiety among people about the boom of data centres. Many are concerned about the water they use.**

The state government has a Green Data Centre Policy, which mandates data centres to use recycled water. Since data centres are also major consumers of energy, the policy requires them to procure or generate green energy as well. Many of the new data centres coming up in Navi Mumbai and surrounding areas fall under CIDCO and the Navi Mumbai Municipal Corporation, which have water treatment plants. These plants treat sewage, and the treated water undergoes further processing through what

## ON STATE OF MUMBAI'S ROADS

*The road quality gets affected due to frequent trenching. We have roughly 27 to 30 utilities that need constant repair. We are developing a trenching policy to incentivise the use of dedicated ducts*



## ON DATA CENTRES AND WATER

*The state government has a Green Data Centre Policy, which mandates data centres to use recycled water... So, in local areas where there are conflicts, there are ways of addressing them*

in its first project, worked with consultants but later, it developed its own capacity to execute and plan projects. Now it itself is a consultant. I keep telling my BMC officers that there are certain areas where only BMC works, nobody else. So, we should be in a position to start our own consultancy at some point of time. Today, DMRC's major revenue comes from their consultancy services because you can't earn revenue only through tickets.

**Nayonika Bose: The change in reservation of Neville D'Souza football ground has once again brought to fore the lack of open spaces in Mumbai. Despite being a coastal city, we have not even been able to develop our seafront to the best capacity. How is the BMC planning to bridge this gap?**

In a city where land itself is a scarcity, we have to be innovative in creating spaces. Currently, the coastal road gardens are being planned and that is being beautifully designed. With that, we will create almost 70 hectares, for sports, performances and just as open gardens where people can gather or just loiter. These are the opportunities which we should utilise.

**Zeeshan Shaikh: Do you think we're doing enough for green cover and parks for the residents in Mumbai?**

Given the area we have, our per capita green space is more than enough. But yes, we can always do better. As city planners, we need to strike a balance with the reality of Mumbai. We have around 30 to 32 lakh trees in the city, when we include trees from Aarey forest. Out of that 2 lakh trees are along the road. This number is good, but equitable distribution is an issue.

Dharavi has less tree cover, which leads to heat generation, making the standard of living even poorer. But, we can do better. We are also mandated to have compensatory re-plantation when trees are required to be cut. There are times we are required to plant 200 trees for five trees cut. Unfortunately, for re-plantation there is no land available, and we plant in the peripheral areas like Panvel or Palghar. In BMC, we have now said that whenever large development happens, and certain amenity plots open up, they will be inventoried and put on GIS. Among those plots, some will not be put to any recreational use but will remain available as gardens. Small plots with trees will therefore be available across the city. With Miyawaki plantation, we can plant almost 1 lakh trees on these plots.

**Sadaf Modak: There are avoidable deaths every monsoon due to landslides and building collapses. Is there any mechanism that needs to be put in place, like forceful evacuation or temporary accommodation?**

Yes, we will at some point look at forceful evacuation. But temporary accommodation is not available as an option in all cases. There is a system for that. From our side, we have now decided, along with the Collector, that after monsoon, we will find out some of the most vulnerable places, and we will try to demolish some of these structures in advance. We will request people to move from those areas, because there is no other alternative.

**Ritika Chopra: If Mumbai were to become a blueprint for development for other megacities, what is the one lesson other cities could emulate and one lesson that they need to avoid?**

I think the first thing is the metro master plan. It was prepared in 2004, and done in a very scientific way. MMRDA conducted a comprehensive transport study for the entire MMR region. They created various futuristic scenarios and picked the most realistic one. So what other cities should do is make a detailed plan for their infrastructure, see where exactly the city is going, what its strong points are, what its weak points are, and which areas need a boost.

Another strong point is that why we complain about the multiplicity of agencies, Mumbai has various agencies which have the nimbleness and action orientation to quickly gear up for taking on big projects. Maybe other cities can think of having specialised agencies or project implementation agencies. What is to be avoided is probably that you can't — you should not — take up so many projects at one go. You should at least plan in such a way that some projects are completed within a short span of time, and then you take up further projects.

**Pratip Acharya: How is the BMC looking at addressing air pollution?**

We cannot look at it in isolation. One of the biggest reasons for air pollution, which is not discussed enough, is the air movement in the whole MMR region and how the wind and dust from these areas circulate. What lies in our hands is how to control the pollution. First is construction activity and the BMC is now monitoring more than 3,000 construction sites where we have mandated full covers, AQI monitors. Our officials have a dashboard to monitor the compliance. Even the RMC plants and sites are now fully covered. Another key factor is vehicular pollution and therefore, the shift to public transport, electric vehicles is also very important. It will happen with time.

Ashwini Bhide, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation Commissioner, on managing floods and air pollution, addressing concerns about data centres and what other cities can learn from Mumbai. The session was moderated by Nayonika Bose, Senior Correspondent, and Pratip Acharya, Principal Correspondent, *The Indian Express*



Ashwini Bhide, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation Commissioner, at the Mumbai office. GANESH SHIRSEKAR

is known as advanced tertiary treatment. The water can then meet very high quality standards, while data centres may carry out additional treatment as required for their operations. Therefore, data centres do not necessarily depend on potable water supplied by municipal corporations. In Mumbai, seven sewage treatment plants (STPs) are currently under construction. Mumbai requires around 4,100 MLD (million litres per day) of water every day, of which approximately 2,400 MLD is converted into sewage. Of the 2,400 MLD, we have so far been treating it only through secondary treatment before releasing it into the sea. However, with the new STPs, this sewage will undergo primary, secondary and tertiary treatment. We expect to recover around 1,200 MLD of water that can be reused in the city for non-potable purposes. This water can be supplied to data centres and other organisations that require water for non-potable uses. It could also eventually be used in households, although that would require separate plumbing systems.

**Zeeshan Shaikh: The other concern is the increase in ambient temperature and the noise the data centres generate. In places like Thane, data centres are coming up near residential areas. Do you think there is a need for a policy on where data centres should be located?**

Mumbai attracts so many data centres due to undersea marine cables that are located near Mumbai and (also in) Chennai. You cannot say that data centres should not be there, we have to co-exist. We have to draw boundaries between the habitable areas and the industrial areas. So, in areas where there are conflicts, there are ways of addressing them. It is a business, it generates jobs, it creates an ecosystem for development. But regulations will be put in place.

**Pratip Acharya: There's more**

**redevelopment in the suburbs. Why has south Mumbai not seen as much redevelopment?**

Redevelopment will come to the city because ultimately it is an economic activity and the function of profitability also plays a part. In our existing scheme, we have guaranteed free housing for people. Even for cessed buildings (pre-1969 structures), there is free housing. Once you give a house free, then it needs to be compensated by somebody. Due to this, even though the city has redevelopment potential, developers weigh their options as to where it would be financially viable. In some areas, there are high restrictions, in some areas, land becomes an issue. In south Mumbai, cessed property, tenanted properties, especially those on BMC and state lease are getting redeveloped but private

properties will weigh their options.

**Nayonika Bose: These projects also churn out large quantum of Construction and Demolition (C&D) waste. Is the city really equipped to handle it and how do we bridge the capacity?**

We generate almost 8,000 metric tonnes of C&D waste every day and BMC themselves have set up plants up to 1200 MT. But, the generated C&D waste is often dumped illegally in old quarries or protected government land. That now needs to be streamlined. What we need is recycling because often C&D waste gets mixed with wood, PoP, stones and bricks. Therefore, we need facilities to segregate and reuse the materials, so that they can go back into other construction work. We have also prepared a portal on the lines of



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## ON CREATING OPEN SPACES

*Where land is scarce, we have to be innovative. Currently, the coastal road gardens are being planned. With that, we will create almost 70 hectares, for sports, performances and open gardens where people can gather or just loiter*

